

RIDING THE DRAGON



A TAOIST MEDITATION GUIDE

LIVIU ARGESEANU



Digitized by the Internet Archive
in 2022 with funding from
Kahle/Austin Foundation

<https://archive.org/details/ridingdragontaoi0000arge>

With More than 50 Drawings and Diagrams Positioned Next to the Exercises

"The benefits of Taoist meditation and its applications to personal lives are analyzed in a title which provides simple answers to questions on meditation practices. From integrating Taoist meditation into daily life to considering routines in different religious practices, this covers everything from techniques to philosophy."

Diane Donovan, "The Midwest Book Review"

"I enjoyed it very much! Clear, concise and easy to understand, it will be of interest to all who wish to know something about Taoist meditation. Full of wisdom and personal insights, I am sure it will appeal to a wide audience of seekers on the path."

Arlene Levine, Teacher and Writer

"As a student of Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation, I found "Riding the Dragon" extremely useful in understanding the practice and underlying philosophy of meditation. With remarkably clear and effective language, insightful analogies, a friendly tone and helpful illustrations, the author explains the art of Taoist meditation and the benefits one can reap through practice."

Michael Suarez, College Student.

"Taoist meditation is a useful tool to get to the center of your well-being. It helps to overcome the frustrations of life and to avoid snap decisions. This book will be a pleasant and helpful adjunct to your daily routine."

Joel Schwartz, Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist Meditation Student.



"Riding The Dragon: A Taoist Meditation Guide" is featured on the Midwest Book Review "home page" on the World Wide Web at <http://www.execpc.com/~mbr/bookwatch/> and on America Online at mwbookrevw@aol.com and on the Internet Online Bookstore at Amazon.com and on The Midwest Book Review television program at WYOU - TV, Madison, WI.

RIDING THE DRAGON

A TAOIST MEDITATION GUIDE

by

Liviu Argeseanu



Apollo Press

Copyright © 1995 by Liviu Argeseanu

All rights reserved. Printed in the United States of America. No part of this book may be reproduced by any mechanical, photographic, or electronic process, or in the form of a phonographic recording, nor may it be stored in a retrieval system, transmitted, or otherwise copied for public or private use, other than for, "fair use," without the prior written permission of the author.

Library of Congress Catalog Card Number: 95-94551

Argeseanu, Liviu.

Riding the dragon : a Taoist meditation guide / by Liviu Argeseanu.

p. cm.

Includes bibliographical references and index.

ISBN 0-9646988-9-7 \$19.95

1. Meditation -- Taoism. 2. Taoism. I. Title.

BL627.A74 1995

291.43

QBI95-20280

First Edition 1995

Second Edition 1996, revised

Illustrations by Dorina Argeseanu

Copy editing by Elizabeth Page

Published by Apollo Press

68-15 Selfridge St. Apt. # 3C

Forest Hills, NY 11375

To Pusha, Johnny, Joel, Michael, Anthony, and Christina

To the memory of my father, Guruji, and Pavel

To Gina,
with best wishes for
health & happiness.

Za
08/18/18.



When we begin to practice meditation,
the more effort, the more progress we make.
Later on, the less effort,
the more progress we make.

Foreword

Taoist meditation, like many other ancient Chinese arts, receiving little attention from the Western world, has been a very important form of technique to enhance one's inner mind and well-being since its very beginning. Taoist meditation covers a wide scale of various techniques from the very fundamental to the very advanced. The fundamental techniques can be learned by anyone with an enthusiastic spirit. Once a person has mastered all of those fundamental techniques, he can continue his studies and practices in the advanced stages. It is knowledge with no limit.

As the days slip between our fingers like sand in an hourglass, unkept traditions are soon forgotten. The same holds true for the ancient art of Taoist meditation. This nearly forgotten form of relaxation has been neglected for far too many years. With other prevalent means of meditation, very few people can be called "master."

To maintain the wealth of knowledge, customs and cultures must be studied and practiced throughout one's entire life. Only after these years of dedication and experience, may one attempt teaching others. When teaching, many new discoveries are uncovered and the master's experience encompasses an even greater range. However, teaching in a limited environment affects only a selected few.

To enlighten more eager people, a true master will save his work for the sake of posterity in some written form. Since most people excel in only one field of living, many proclaimed masters cannot write proficiently. When this happens, the book is no longer a pleasure to read, but becomes a tedious responsibility.

Few books meet the rigid standards of the public, no matter what the subject is. However, Liviu Argeseanu will astonish you with his knowledge of the forgotten art of Taoist meditation. Not only will his rendition leave you in awe, but his writing style will make you wish the book has no ending. I extend my deep appreciation and congratulation to him.

This book will first briefly review the basics and show the fundamental training. Finally, a section of common questions and answers about Taoist meditation is being incorporated into this guide. This book is written primarily for those people who want to know something about Taoist meditation but never had the opportunity to explore this topic. It is, however, also very suitable for those Taoist meditation practitioners to use it as a reference and guide to enhance his/her practices.

Dr. Paul C. Lu
Michael T. Lu

Preface

Over the years I have met several remarkable men. These people helped me in my search toward enlightenment. Among these, Master *Chu* is the person whose teachings have been most helpful to me. He gave me the strength to make several crucial decisions that changed my life.

The meditation method described here is based on the teachings of *Chen Wei Ming* in his *Tai Chi Chuan* treatise, "Questions and Answers by Chen Wei Ming." It was further developed by Master *Chu* and later on by myself.

I have also included some personal experiences with Taoist meditation, benefits of meditation and examples of how Taoism can be used as a way of living.

While I was working on "Riding the Dragon: A Taoist Meditation Guide," I had to search carefully before reaching the essence. In my struggle to express ideas with clarity, I have reviewed this book many times, polishing it until I finally felt satisfied with its form and content.

Over the years of studying and later on teaching I became aware of the benefits of Taoist meditation for the student. My goal is to share these benefits with the reader, so everybody can take advantage of the support that Taoist meditation provides in daily life.

Liviu Argeseanu

A Note to the Reader

This book was written to introduce Taoist meditation as well as the warm-up and the massage techniques associated with it. Because these exercises may be new to some people and because every individual is different, please consult your physician before you try any of the contents of this book, for your protection.

The author specifically disclaims liability for any loss or risk incurred by the use or application of any of the contents of this book.

If you do not want to be bound by the above warning-disclaimer, you may return this book to the publisher for a full refund.

Note: Look in the glossary for the words in <i>italics</i> , as well as for the pronunciation of Chinese words.
--

Table of Contents

FOREWORD.....	7
PREFACE.....	9
TABLE OF FIGURES.....	13
INTRODUCTION	15
<u>PART I. THE REASON FOR MEDITATION</u>	
A MODEST INSIGHT ABOUT TAOISM	19
BENEFITS OF TAOIST MEDITATION.....	21
PERSONAL EXPERIENCES WITH TAOIST MEDITATION	25
<u>PART II. THE PRACTICE</u>	
PREREQUISITES FOR SUCCESSFUL MEDITATION.....	29
1. <i>The Head</i>	29
2. <i>The Legs</i>	30
3. <i>The Hands</i>	31
4. <i>The Eyes</i>	33
5. <i>The Face</i>	33
6. <i>The Teeth</i>	33
7. <i>The Tongue</i>	33
BEFORE MEDITATION WARM-UP TECHNIQUES.....	35
<i>Foot Reflexology</i>	36
<i>Butterfly Technique</i>	37
MEDITATION STEPS.....	39
1. <i>Sitting Straight</i>	40
2. <i>Breathing Deeply</i>	40
3. <i>Feeling the Tan Tien</i>	41
4. <i>Rounding out</i>	42
5. <i>Counting</i>	42
6. <i>Letting go</i>	43
AFTER MEDITATION MASSAGE TECHNIQUES	45
1. <i>The Head</i>	45
2. <i>The Body</i>	50
3. <i>The Legs</i>	55
4. <i>The Hips</i>	56
5. <i>The Knees</i>	57
6. <i>The Ankles</i>	58
7. <i>Stretching Technique</i>	59
8. <i>Yoga Technique</i>	60
9. <i>Energy Balancing Technique</i>	62
10. <i>Relaxation</i>	63
11. <i>Application of Massage Techniques for Health</i>	64
MEDITATION STAGES	65
<i>First Stage - Stillness</i>	65
<i>Second Stage - Detachment</i>	66
<i>Third Stage - Quietness</i>	67
<i>Fourth Stage - Wisdom</i>	68
ADVANCED BREATHING TECHNIQUES	71
<i>First Level - Deep Breathing Exercises</i>	71
<i>Second Level - Rapid Breathing Exercises</i>	71
<i>Additional Points</i>	73
INTEGRATION OF TAOIST MEDITATION INTO DAILY LIFE	75
NUTRITION	85
APPLICATION OF TAOIST MEDITATION IN MARTIAL ARTS.....	87
QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS.....	91
THE ESSENCE.....	127
<u>APPENDIX</u>	
BIBLIOGRAPHY	129
GLOSSARY	131
INDEX.....	137
ABOUT THE AUTHOR	139
YIN AND YANG.....	140
THE WARM RAIN	141

Table of Figures

FIGURE 1 - YELLOW EMPEROR	20
FIGURE 2 - SITTING STRAIGHT	29
FIGURE 3 - SITTING IN LOTUS -- LEFT FOOT FIRST	30
FIGURE 4 - TAOIST MEDITATION STANCE FOR HANDS	31
FIGURE 5 - SITTING IN LOTUS -- RIGHT FOOT FIRST	32
FIGURE 6 - TONGUE POSITION	33
FIGURE 7 - LEGS WARM-UP -- STEPS A. AND B.	35
FIGURE 8 - SOLE MASSAGE	36
FIGURE 9 - BUTTERFLY TECHNIQUE	37
FIGURE 10 - THE SIX STEPS OF MEDITATION	39
FIGURE 11 - TAN TIEN LOCATION STEPS A. AND B.	41
FIGURE 12 - ROUNDING OUT	42
FIGURE 13 - EYE MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	45
FIGURE 14 - EYE MASSAGE -- STEP C.	46
FIGURE 15 - NOSE MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	46
FIGURE 16 - NOSE MASSAGE -- STEPS C. AND D.	47
FIGURE 17 - HEAD RUBBING MASSAGE	48
FIGURE 18 - JADE PILLOW AREA MASSAGE	48
FIGURE 19 - TEMPLE AND EAR MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	49
FIGURE 20 - ABDOMEN CIRCULAR MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	50
FIGURE 21 - LOWER ABDOMEN MASSAGE	51
FIGURE 22 - SOLAR PLEXUS MASSAGE	52
FIGURE 23 - STOMACH MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	53
FIGURE 24 - LOWER BACK MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	54
FIGURE 25 - LEGS MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	55
FIGURE 26 - HIPS MASSAGE	56
FIGURE 27 - KNEES MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	57
FIGURE 28 - ANKLES MASSAGE -- STEPS A. AND B.	58
FIGURE 29 - STRETCHING	59
FIGURE 30 - VIPARITA KARANI MUDRA	60
FIGURE 31 - ENERGY BALANCING	62
FIGURE 32 - THE ENERGY CYCLE	79
FIGURE 33 - THE ENERGY PYRAMID	80
FIGURE 34 - YIN AND YANG SYMBOL	87
FIGURE 35 - PUSH HANDS	89
FIGURE 36 - ABDOMINAL BREATHING EXERCISE	105
FIGURE 37 - ABDOMINAL BREATHING DIAGRAM -- STEPS A. AND B.	107
FIGURE 38 - TUCKING IN	108
FIGURE 39 - KICK WITH THE HEEL	109
FIGURE 40 - LAO TSE	115
FIGURE 41 - EMBRACE HORSE	132
FIGURE 42 - PLAY PI PA	134
FIGURE 43 - THE SMALL ORBIT	135

Introduction

Last summer I was playing Tai Chi Chuan on an outdoor platform by the lake at Ananda Ashram in upstate New York. After completing the *Long Form*, I planned to attend meditation in the Main House. It was a quiet evening and I could hear the geese swimming on the lake.

Then I heard my son. He was making all kinds of weird sounds, like "Hee Haa," so it was easy to locate him on the property. I found him sitting all by himself in the dining hall. He looked rather sad and lonely. At that point I felt that it was a lot more important to be with him than to attend the program in the Main House. So I canceled all my plans and stayed with my son in the dining hall. We unloaded his Lego box on a table and started to build. My hands worked by themselves and after a while a flying dragon came into being. My son was building a boat. We had a wonderful time playing together.

That is when it occurred to me that the title for this book should be "Riding the Dragon." The dragon is the mind. Riding the dragon is controlling the mind. Most of the time we make our own lives miserable, rather than external events causing our misery. This is how meditation comes into play because meditation can help us to control the mind. When we can control our mind, we do not become our own enemy.

From the beginning of time there has been a powerful need to find the meaning of life. In order to find out this meaning, you have to first learn how to listen. Then, with patience, new doors will open. Meditation teaches how to listen because meditation is sitting quietly without thinking. Only when you stop thinking, can you start to listen to the universe as well as to your inner being.



PART I.

**THE REASON
FOR
MEDITATION**

A Modest Insight about Taoism

T

aoism is more a way of living than a religion or a philosophy. It was developed in China over 6,000 years ago as a way of healthy living by keeping the body and mind in harmony.

At the root of *Taoism* is the principle of *yin* and *yang*, which are two opposite entities that are omnipresent in nature. Yin is the female passive energy usually associated with softness, coolness, darkness and yielding. Yang, on the other side, is the masculine active energy usually associated with hardness, heat, light and unyielding. Since all beings are made both of yin and yang, when those two

energies are in balance a person is mentally and physically healthy.

Several healing techniques evolved from Taoism: acupuncture, acupressure, medicinal herbs therapy, macrobiotic diet, Shiatsu, *Reiki* and massage. These all work on restoring the balance between yin and yang in the body.

Lao Tse, who lived in China almost 3,000 years ago, is considered to be the founder of Taoism. His foremost work, the "Tao Te Ching," is an enlightened treatise about how to live one's life in harmony with nature and with respect toward other people. Its compassion toward other beings and its clear understanding of human nature make it a most useful companion in this age or any age.

A good example of Taoism applied to politics and military art is the "Art of War" by Sun Tzu. Master Sun imparts a way of waging war while generating as few casualties as possible. War could be necessary at times as a way of defending

one's land but "enjoying in killing and destruction" only brings desolation upon one-self. The art of war is the art of winning a battle without even pulling one's sword from its sheath, thus avoiding unnecessary bloodshed.

During the reign of the Yellow Emperor, an internal complex of exercises – *Nei Kung* -- was created, based on Taoism, in order to enhance the body's energy, *chi*.

Taoist meditation applies the ideas of Taoism to the art of calming one's body and mind. When you empty your mind and no thinking is going on, then it becomes easier for the body's energy, *chi*, to flow freely along energy channels, *meridians*. Accordingly, a self-healing process goes on during meditation and the balance between yin and yang is restored by itself. After completing the meditation you feel rejuvenated, energetic and calm -- ready to take on another day of work. Also, Taoist meditation is blended with the art of Chinese self-massage, thus maintaining the health of both the body and mind.

As Taoism becomes more and more frequently talked about in books and magazines, so does Taoist meditation which is as relevant today as a way of controlling stress and anxiety as it was 6,000 years ago.



Figure 1 - Yellow Emperor

Benefits of Taoist Meditation

W

hen we let go of our daily worries and we just sit still, time is perceived differently. Like honey flowing smoothly from a pot, time becomes liquid and accordingly it loses its grip on us.

Meditation is simply sitting quietly without thinking. Though it appears to be a very easy exercise, learning meditation requires a lot of perseverance and determination. But this effort can make a big difference in our lives.

Many people are unhappy nowadays because they do not give themselves time to observe the blue sky. When you become aware of the immensity of the sky, the dimension of your worries appears much smaller, and it becomes easier to smile.

Like observing the sky, meditation helps us to get a different perspective on life. We smile at the world and we smile at ourselves. We just are, beyond all opposites, beyond all struggles. We replenish ourselves with the quietness that existed before the world was born. We stop running; gradually, we become more detached and less afraid of life.

Taoist meditation, with its unique technique, benefits our whole being. This method emphasizes correct body alignment and accordingly it becomes easier for the body's vital energy, *chi*, to flow freely in the body. When the flow of energy is better, sickness becomes less likely. So regular practice of meditation helps to prevent disease altogether.

With practice, the back muscles become stronger and thus our posture improves. Also, the joints become more flexible and the bones become harder. The body's stiffness melts away under the gentle massage that is done after meditation.

Taoist meditation makes it possible to let go and empty the mind. On a psychological level, Taoist meditation is geared toward building self-control and confidence in oneself.

Meditation improves the power of concentration and strengthens the memory. Therefore it can become a helpful tool in daily life and in children's education.

With practice, there is also increased visual acuity. Meditation works on transforming the lower level energy, *chi*, into higher level energy, *shen*. *Shen* radiates through the eyes and it can be noticed especially in children because their eyes are more alert.



The techniques used in Taoist meditation can also be applied when confronted by somebody who is very angry or very anxious. Simply breathe deeply and shift your attention to the lower *Tan Tien* (see the third step of the Taoist meditation on page 41). This helps avoid being affected by the anger or anxiety of the other person. In such

circumstances, if you are not physically attacked, do not make eye contact (you can look down). This keeps you calm and focused on avoiding a confrontation.

In the same way that fish swim for deeper waters when an ocean storm is nearby, we dive deeper inside ourselves and let the waves of anger and anxiety pass by without getting involved. This method, together with a willingness not to fight every battle, helped me to avoid many conflicts, made my life easier and let me enjoy life more. But this attitude may be difficult in our society which views inaction as cowardice.

Meditation also helps to build patience. If we can be more patient with our children, we can understand and communicate better with them. The relationship between parents and children becomes a more pleasant one, and we can start to enjoy our children rather than force them, as we so often do, to do what we think is best for them. After I taught Taoist meditation to my son, our relationship improved. We now share an important thing: our practice.



After meditation you get insight and it becomes easier to find your inner nature. For instance, suppose you have a gift for playing violin but your family insists that

accounting is a more lucrative business. So you slowly push aside your inclination and forget about playing violin. You go to work to make a living, but you are not too happy. You feel that something is missing in your life. After meditation you rediscover your inner nature and you may choose to go back to your calling. Meditation helped me to change my career and to work in a field that gives me more fulfillment.

In the book, "Be as You Are: The Teachings of Ramana Maharishi," I found these lines,

"Where are you going? You are not going anywhere.
The Self does not move, but the world moves in the Self."

This means that no matter where you go you cannot run away from yourself. Meditation helps us to live with ourselves, to accept ourselves the way we really are, with our flaws and weaknesses but also with our strengths and determination.

Taoist meditation helps you to become more energetic and more clear-minded. You gain control over your life and become the master over your decisions, rather than surrender to some enlightened *guru* and live in his shadow -- you discover your own "inner guru."



Personal Experiences with Taoist Meditation

Q uite often when I have had to face difficult decisions in my life, I found help in meditation because frequently after meditation the answer to my problems came to me spontaneously. So I came to rely on meditation as a good way to deal with my daily struggles.

I have been doing some form of *yoga* meditation for the last 20 years. In the early years it seemed to work only on "sunny days." That is, when I was in a quiet place like an ashram (a community that is geared toward the practice of *yoga*), I was able to relax and let go, but when I got back home, in the middle of so many conflicting demands on me, meditation did not "work" anymore.

Only after I had learned Taoist meditation, did I realize that I finally had an "all-weather coat." Meditation should help you to let go of your thoughts every time you practice it. If you can relax only in a remote place, away from the daily struggles, but cannot do so at home, you may want to look into Taoist meditation as a more effective form of relaxation.

When you are driving a car at 60 miles per hour, it will take more time to stop than at 20 miles per hour. In the same way, it will take more time to relax when you have a lot of worries than when you are peaceful. But like the car, you should be able to stop thinking and let go within a reasonable time.

Meditation can be of support in your daily life just as it has been for me for many years. When everything else falls apart, meditation is something to hang onto. It helps us find a space within ourselves where we can take refuge and heighten our awareness. It can act like the anchor of a ship because it gets us rooted in a reality beyond time and space. Through meditation, we connect to that place in us that does not change with age. Meditation is a means that helps us get in touch with our immortality.

Sometimes during meditation I enter into a trance-like state that is accompanied by some physical changes. For example, the breath becomes deeper, the heartbeat becomes slower, the body temperature rises and the saliva in my mouth becomes sweet and feels very nourishing. A vegetarian diet helps to enhance these changes.

These physical effects of meditation resemble the activation of the *parasympathetic nervous system*. Taoist meditation, like the parasympathetic nervous system, conserves and replenishes the energy of the body. After meditation I feel more energetic, almost like a child.



PART II.

THE PRACTICE

Prerequisites for Successful Meditation

T

he following technical elements are necessary for a successful meditation:

1. The Head

The head should be held as if it is suspended from above. One needs to sit with the back straight like a candle so the chi (energy) can circulate through the body and ultimately sink down to the lower Tan Tien (lower abdomen).



Figure 2 - Sitting Straight

Sit on a hard surface, like the floor, so it will be easier to sit straight. If you have back problems you can lean against the wall or sit on a straight chair.

2. The Legs

Many students sit with the legs crossed in Indian fashion because the *Lotus* position (shown in Figure 3 and Figure 5) requires a lot of flexibility. In the beginning you can sit on a pillow to ease the pressure on your knees and ankles. If it is too painful to stay with your legs bent for a long time, you can start by sitting on a chair with the soles of your feet touching the floor.

The legs ideally will be in the Lotus position (one leg bent at the knee with the heel touching the lower abdomen and the other leg bent over it, with the heel touching the other side of the lower abdomen). In Lotus, the body balance is better and the legs' meridians (energy channels) are closed.

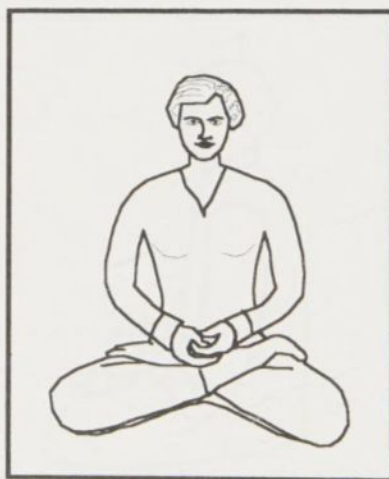


Figure 3 - Sitting in Lotus -- Left Foot First

If you practice "sitting" on a regular basis, your legs will become more flexible and eventually you will be able to sit in Lotus. Whenever you eat or watch television, you

can practice sitting in Lotus or sitting with the legs crossed. You do not have to sit on the floor; you can sit in Lotus on a straight chair to get some back support.

3. The Hands

The hands should be positioned in front of the body, forming a circle. This helps to conserve energy because the body's meridians are closed. The thumb and the middle finger of the left hand touch each other. The thumb of the right hand touches the base of the middle finger of the left hand. Then the left hand rests on the palm of the right hand. This is called the Taoist meditation stance for hands.

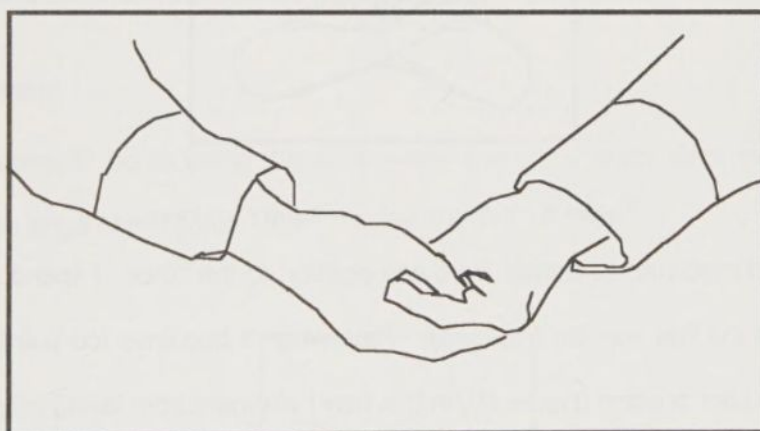


Figure 4 - Taoist Meditation Stance for Hands

If you enter Lotus with your left foot first, then you should start your hand position with your left hand. You will end up with your right foot on top of the left leg and your left hand on the palm of the right hand.

Riding the Dragon

If you enter Lotus with your right foot first, then you should begin your hand position with your right hand. You will end up with your left foot on top of the right leg and your right hand on the palm of the left hand. In both cases the hands and feet balance each other.

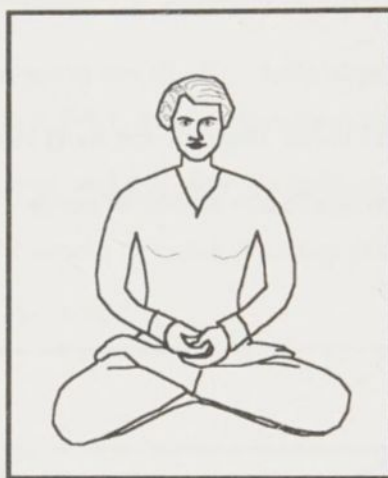


Figure 5 - Sitting in Lotus -- Right Foot First

When I meditate, I alternate from one position to the other. I spend about 10 to 15 minutes in the first position (Figure 3). Then when it becomes too painful to hold, I switch to the other position (Figure 5). In this way I alternate from laying more stress on my right knee and left ankle (Figure 3) to laying more stress on my left knee and right ankle (Figure 5).

Though in the beginning it is painful to stay in Lotus, as time goes by you will become used to it. After a while you will get to appreciate Lotus as an ideal position for meditation. From my experience, I learned that Lotus helps in improving the elasticity of

the hip, knee and ankle joints. However, do not try too much too soon; give yourself time to adjust to it and increase the sitting time gradually.

4. The Eyes

The eyes are slightly open (close eyes and then barely open them to allow a little light in). The eyes should not focus on any object or point.

5. The Face

There should be a slight smile -- like a Buddha.

6. The Teeth

The upper and lower teeth should be touching gently.

7. The Tongue

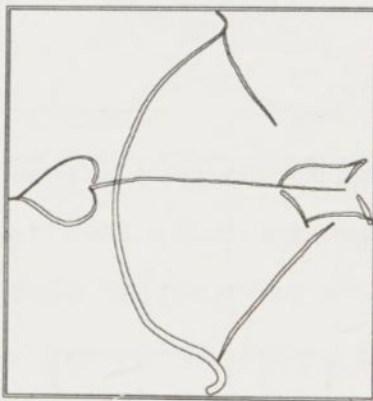
The tongue should be touching the area where the upper teeth meet the roof of the mouth (at the edge of the gum).



Figure 6 - Tongue Position

Riding the Dragon

All these technical elements are important. In archery, if you make a small error when you aim the arrow, by the time the arrow reaches its destination it will miss the target by a few feet. But if you get everything right from the beginning, there is a good chance that you will hit the center of the target (the bull's eye). In the same way as with the bow and the arrow, your body and mind have to be focused to be able to learn the art of meditation.



Before Meditation Warm-up Techniques

W

ith the following exercises, we warm up the legs before meditation:

- a. Sit with the right leg extended and the left leg bent over it. Press gently with the left hand on the left knee as in Figure 7 a.
- b. Reverse the legs and sit with the left leg extended and the right leg bent over it. Press gently with the right hand on the right knee as in Figure 7 b.



a.



b.

Figure 7 - Legs Warm-up -- Steps a. and b.

Foot Reflexology

As you press gently on the knee of the bent leg with one hand, with the other hand massage the sole of the foot.

The black circle indicates an *acupuncture point*, a valve that controls the flow of energy in the body. This point is called "bubbling spring" and is the most important point of the kidney meridian.

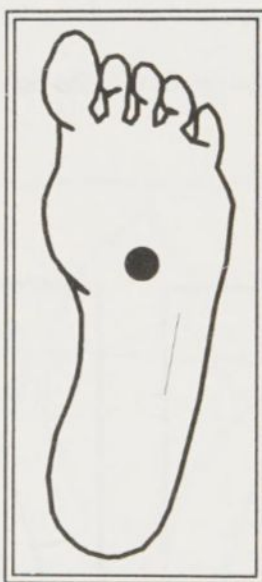


Figure 8 - Sole Massage

If you press with the thumb in this area on a regular basis, the hip, knee and ankle joints will become more flexible. Because the kidneys are the source of energy in the body, this massage is also good for general fatigue.

Butterfly Technique

Bend the legs so that the soles of the feet touch each other and the heels are close to the groin. Then interlock the fingers, grip the feet firmly and sit straight. The legs move up and down like the wings of a butterfly.

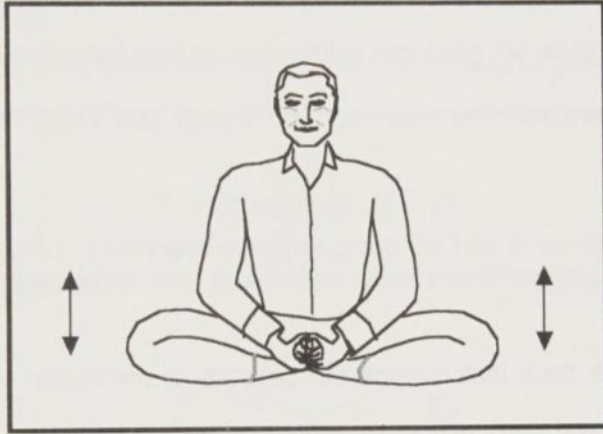


Figure 9 - Butterfly Technique



37

Riding the Dragon

Warm up for about 10 to 15 minutes. Please, take your time when you warm up the legs. If you do not warm up enough, your legs will hurt when you are in meditation and you will not be able to relax and let go of your thoughts.

The next chapter explains the steps that we go through during meditation. In each of them we focus on a particular element. A good compromise is to sit with the legs crossed in Indian fashion during the first five steps and to enter Lotus before the last step. In this way you will get some extra warm-up time before you enter Lotus.

After you complete the warm-up and before you begin the meditation, tell yourself:

"For the next hour or so I am going to ignore everything. I am going to use this time to learn more about myself and I am not going to get distracted."

Some people think that through the practice of meditation you become aloof, separated from the real world, but this is not true. On the contrary, after meditation we become more aware of the world and of our inner life. However, we need to be alone for a while to get in harmony with the universe. Like the battery of a car that needs to be charged in order to be able to start the engine, we need to charge ourselves through the practice of meditation.



38

Meditation Steps

We go through a series of five preparatory steps before the real meditation (step six). It is like climbing a ladder: each preparatory step is a step on the ladder that leads to meditation. If we try to meditate right away, often we find it impossible because there are too many thoughts going on in our mind.

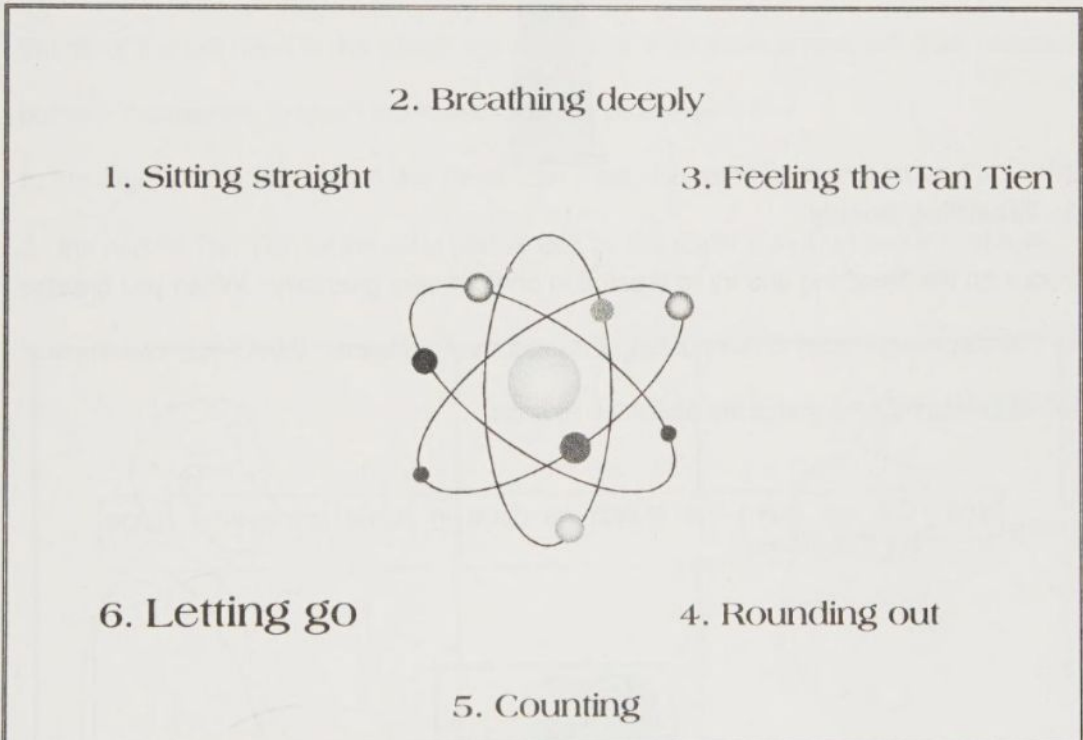


Figure 10 - The Six Steps of Meditation

It happens sometimes that you lose your concentration. If you become aware of this, just bring your mind back on the right track without any guilt; after all, we are human.

39

The following steps help us to enter into meditation:

1. Sitting Straight

Focus on the correct body alignment, with the backbone straight. Imagine the head to be suspended from above like a cloth hanging on a string.



2. Breathing Deeply

Focus on the breathing and try to breathe in and out very gradually. When you breathe in, the diaphragm goes down pushing the abdomen outward. When you breathe out, the diaphragm goes up and the abdomen retracts.

Note: Do not count the breath as done in some *pranayama* (yoga breathing techniques).

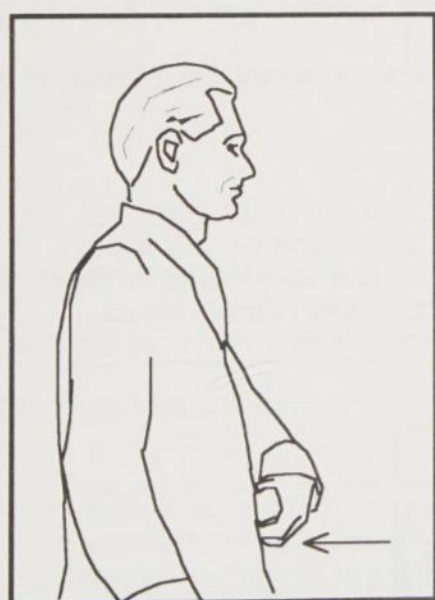


40

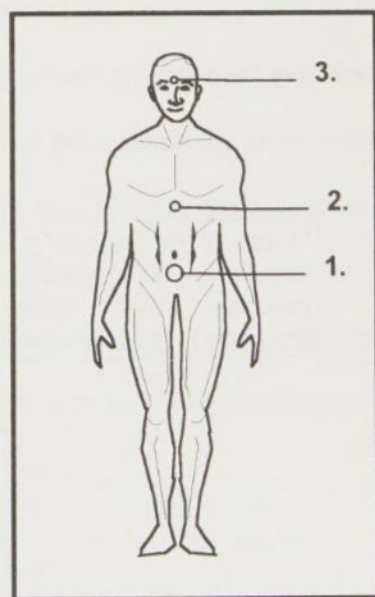
3. Feeling the Tan Tien

Concentrate on the lower Tan Tien (nervous plexus that is located about two inches below the navel and one inch inside). The Tan Tien is like a sphere about an inch wide. In the beginning you can press with the index and middle fingers into the lower Tan Tien to make it easier to focus on it. When you become more advanced, you can focus on it just mentally.

- a. It is easy to find the lower Tan Tien if you use the following technique: place the thumb of the left hand in the navel; the index and the middle fingers will then naturally position themselves to touch the lower Tan Tien as in Figure 11 a.
- b. In Figure 11 b are shown the three Tan Tien: 1. represents the lower Tan Tien, 2. the middle Tan Tien or the solar plexus and 3. the upper Tan Tien or the third eye.



a.



b.

Figure 11 - Tan Tien Location Steps a. and b.

4. Rounding out

Focus on the roundness of the body. The hands make a circle as they rest positioned in front of the body. Imagine yourself like a sphere, ready to float in the sky.

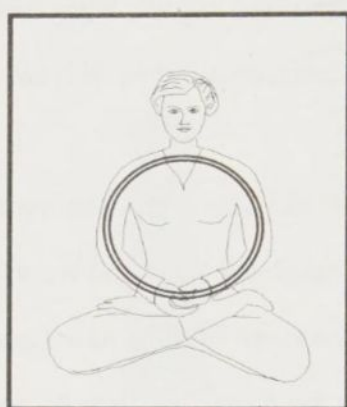


Figure 12 - Rounding out

5. Counting

Count from one to ten, repeatedly. The reason for this repetition is to stop the thinking machinery by engaging the mind in a meaningless task. A *mantra*, the repetition of a certain word, will achieve the same goal.

Note: In the beginning you may have a lot of thoughts on your mind; therefore, you should count fast in order to be able to silence all other thoughts. After a while, because you become more relaxed, you can gradually reduce the speed of counting.



42

6. Letting go

This is the real meditation and the five previous steps are only preparatory steps. Let go of your thoughts, both pleasant and unpleasant, and sit quietly without thinking.

The mind gravitates toward activity. However, through the practice of meditation you go beyond the mind's tendency for thinking into the uncharted spaces of emptiness. It took me many years to understand emptiness. Emptiness is not like a cup without water; rather, it means being like a cup with still water.

"The mind is still -- no thoughts."



This does not mean that biological sensations like hunger, thirst and pain disappear. If you are hungry or thirsty, a cup of water or tea can help you feel better. If you do not sit straight, after a while your back will hurt. After some time the legs can feel stiff. If you experience pain, you should readjust your posture to feel more comfortable.

Note: "Letting go" is particularly difficult because the mind has a natural apprehension of losing control. Only with perseverance and regular practice, can one go beyond the barrier of the mind.

Ideally, you can practice meditation like this: spend about five minutes in each of the first five steps and about ten minutes in the last step, the real meditation. If you rush through the preparatory steps (1-5), by the time you get to the sixth step you will not be able to empty your mind and you have only wasted your time. Therefore take your time, stay long enough in each of the preparatory steps to feel rooted in it -- then you will be able to let go of your thoughts and your meditation will make progress.

Sometimes we still have a difficult time letting go. If this is so we can go back to counting or even go back to the first step and start over. When you attain a high level in meditation, you can shorten the preparatory steps and spend more time in the last step; but do this only when you are ready for it.

Meditation is a self-healing therapy because our body and mind have the knowledge of how to heal themselves. A journey of tranquillity has just begun -- when we sit quietly, our body resets itself to the way it was as a newborn baby.



After Meditation Massage Techniques



fter meditation, massage all the parts of the body starting with the head and continuing with the body and the legs. During meditation the body generates and stores a lot of energy. The massage helps to spread the released energy evenly throughout the body.

1. The Head

1.1. The Eyes

a. Face Massage

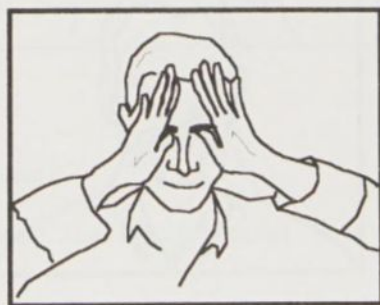
Rub your hands together rapidly until they get warm and gently massage your face (Figure 13 a.).

b. Stimulating the Eyes

Rest the head gently on the thumbs above the bridge of the nose and above the tear ducts. Here there is an acupuncture point that helps to improve vision (Figure 13 b.).



a.



b.

Figure 13 - Eye Massage -- Steps a. and b.

c. Energizing the Eyes

Next rub the hands and then cover the eyes with the heel of the palms. You should feel the heat from the hands penetrating the eyes.



Figure 14 - Eye Massage -- Step c.

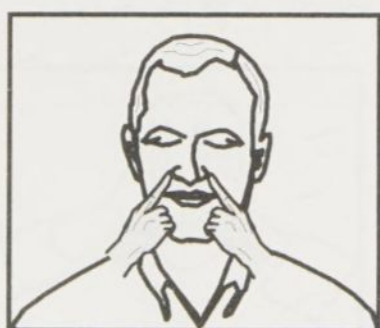
1.2. The Nose

a. Press down at the base of the nose, on both sides, with the index fingers as in

Figure 15 a. Then rub gently in a circular motion.

b. Press the points midway up on each side of the nose with the index fingers as in

Figure 15 b. Then rub gently in a circular motion.



a.



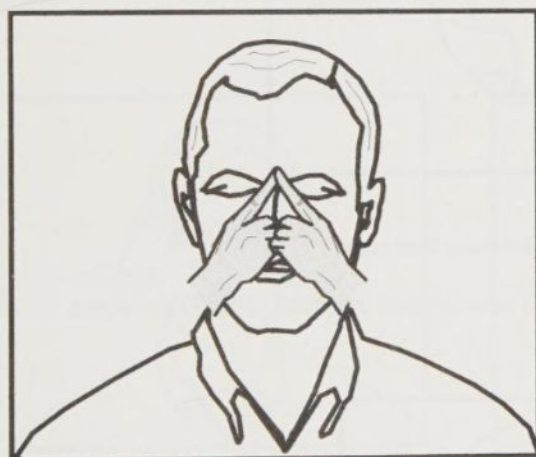
b.

Figure 15 - Nose Massage -- Steps a. and b.

c. Press the point located between the eyebrows (the third eye) with both index fingers (one finger on top of the other as you touch the third eye) as in Figure 16 c. Then rub gently in a circular motion. Repeat these steps (a., b., c.) at least three times.

d. Rub in a continuous motion with the index fingers starting at the base of the nose and going through the midway points up to the third eye. Continue, following the central line of the head all the way up, and then going down to the *Jade Pillow Area* (protuberance located where the nape of the neck meets the skull) as in Figure 16 d.

Repeat this massage at least three times.



c.



d.

Figure 16 - Nose Massage -- Steps c. and d.

Step d. of the nose massage is executed in a deep, continuous motion.

1.3. The Upper Part of the Head

a. Rub your hands for heat and then massage the upper part of the head, using our fingers like a comb. You can enhance this massage with small back and forth movements for a deep, vigorous massage. Repeat at least three times.



Figure 17 - Head Rubbing Massage

b. Press with the thumbs or the index fingers around and into the Jade Pillow Area.

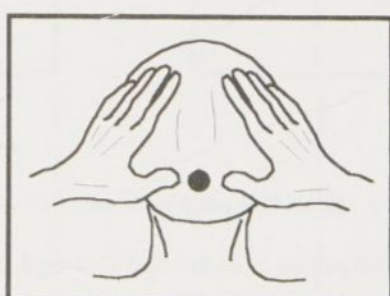


Figure 18 - Jade Pillow Area Massage

The black circle shows where the Jade Pillow Area is located.

The Jade Pillow Area works like a gate that controls the flow of energy on the dorsal side of the body. Sometimes I feel a tingling in the Jade Pillow Area during meditation. It tells me that the gate is open and the energy is flowing freely through the *Small Orbit* (see Glossary).

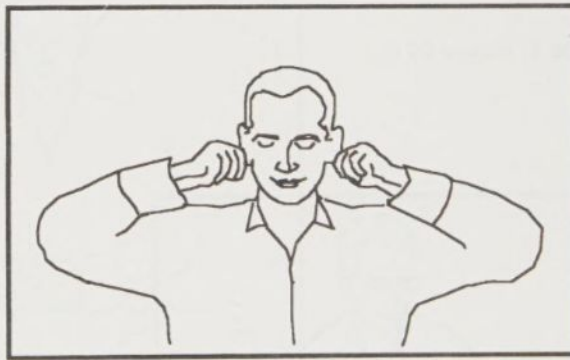
1.4. The Temples and Ears

a. Rub the hands for heat and then gently massage the face, especially the temple area as in Figure 19 a.

b. Then massage the ears by squeezing and pulling the ears away from the head as in Figure 19 b. Massage the whole surface of the ears.



a.



b.

Figure 19 - Temple and Ear Massage -- Steps a. and b.

End the massage by tapping lightly on the head with the knuckles, keeping the wrists relaxed.

2. The Body

2.1. Abdomen Circular Massage

Massage the abdomen in a circular motion.

a. Counterclockwise

Place the heel of the right hand on the lower right side of the abdomen with the left hand on top of it. Then massage the abdomen circling the navel counterclockwise as in Figure 20 a.

b. Clockwise

Place the heel of the left hand on the lower left side of the abdomen with the right hand on top of it. Then massage the abdomen circling the navel clockwise as in Figure 20 b.



a.



b.

Figure 20 - Abdomen Circular Massage -- Steps a. and b.

50

After Meditation Massage Techniques

The abdomen circular massage consists of two steps: first we push down toward the Tan Tien, then we pull up to complete the circle. You will find that the lower half of the massage goes deeper than the upper half. Do not forget to relax the abdomen!

The abdomen massage helps to activate the lower Tan Tien which works like an energy reservoir and is a vital part of our body.

2.2. Lower Abdomen Massage

Place the heel of the right hand below the navel with the left hand on top of it. Then massage the lower abdomen by twisting only the upper body from right to left and back.



Figure 21 - Lower Abdomen Massage

The hands and the upper body move together, so you can massage the abdomen deeper.

The abdomen massage is executed in a deep, continuous motion. You should feel comfortable during the massage.

If done correctly you will feel heat in the areas being massaged. Also, use only one layer of clothing during massage.

2.3. Solar Plexus Massage

Place the heel of the right hand on the solar plexus with the left hand on top of it. Then massage the abdomen by rubbing gently up and down.

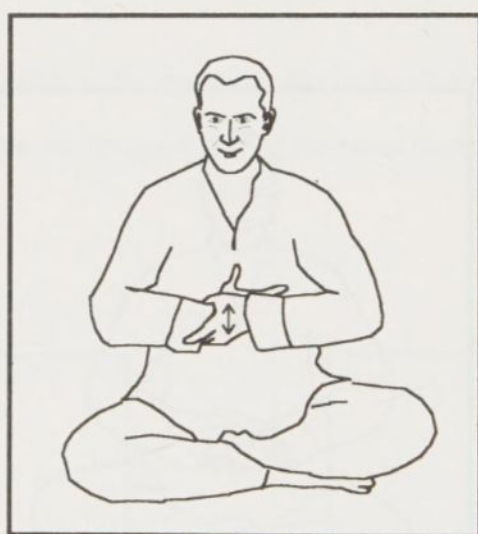


Figure 22 - Solar Plexus Massage

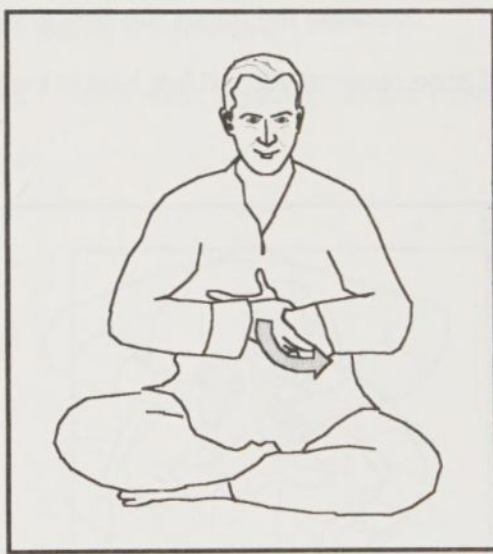
Because the solar plexus is a sensitive area, this massage is done gently. Therefore it is less likely that heat will be felt during this massage.

2.4. Stomach Massage

- a. Place the heel of the right hand on the solar plexus with the left hand on top of it. Then massage the stomach by pressing gently below the edge of the ribs toward the right side of the chest as in Figure 23 a.
- b. Place the heel of the left hand on the solar plexus with the right hand on top of it. Then massage the stomach by pressing gently below the edge of the ribs toward the left side of the chest as in Figure 23 b.



a.



b.

Figure 23 - Stomach Massage -- Steps a. and b.

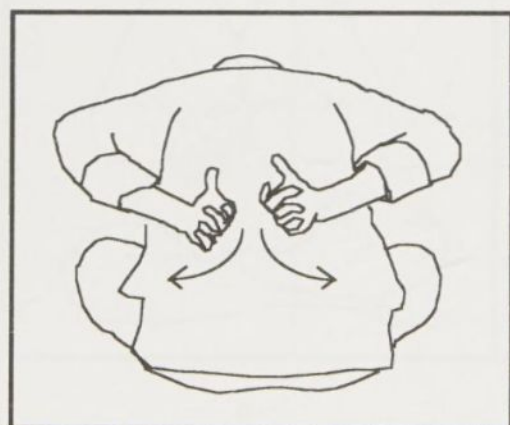
Because the stomach is a sensitive area, this massage is done gently. Therefore, it is less likely that heat will be felt during this massage.

2.5. Lower Back Massage

a. Massage the lower back in a circular motion with the fists, wrists or heel of the palms as in Figure 24 a. In order to massage the lower back better, bend forward so that the kidney area extends.

b. Position the hands behind the back, with the left hand holding the edge of the right hand. Then bend forward and massage the lower spine by rubbing it up and down with the back of the hands as in Figure 24 b. Repeat the massage with the right hand now holding the edge of the left hand.

Because the hands are connected, you can massage the lower back deeper. If done correctly you will feel heat in the lower back.



a.



b.

Figure 24 - Lower Back Massage -- Steps a. and b.

End the massage by tapping lightly on the lower back with the back of the hands.

3. The Legs

a. Outer Side

With the heel of the palms, vigorously massage the outer side along the entire length of each leg, ending with the flat of the hands on the feet as in Figure 25 a.

Keep the legs close to each other, so you can massage them deeper. The body moves forward and backward in a rowing type of motion.

b. Inner Side

With the heel of the palms, vigorously massage the inner side along the entire length of each leg, ending with the flat of the hands on the feet as in Figure 25 b.

Keep the legs apart so you can reach the inside of each leg easily. Again, move the body as if rowing.



a.



b.

Figure 25 - Legs Massage -- Steps a. and b.

Continue this massage until you feel the heat of friction develop.

4. The Hips

Vigorously massage the hip area in a circular motion with the flat of the palms. The legs are held fairly flat on the floor, but keep them close to each other so you can massage the hips more thoroughly.



Figure 26 - Hips Massage

Lean back slightly as you massage the hips. If done correctly you will feel heat in the areas being massaged.

5. The Knees

a. Outer Side

Vigorously massage the outer side of the knees in a circular motion with the flat of the palms as in Figure 27 a. The legs are held fairly flat on the floor, but keep them close to each other so you can massage the knees more thoroughly.

b. Inner Side

Vigorously massage the inner side of the knees in a circular motion with the flat of the palms as in Figure 27 b. The legs are held fairly flat on the floor, but turn the knees outward for convenience.



a.



b.

Figure 27 - Knees Massage -- Steps a. and b.

c. Under the Knee

Vigorously massage the area behind the knee by rubbing it back and forth with the flat of the hands. If done correctly you will feel heat in the areas being massaged.

57

6. The Ankles

a. Left Ankle

Bend the left leg at the knee and massage the left ankle in a circular motion with the flat of the hands as in Figure 28 a.

b. Right Ankle

Bend the right leg at the knee and massage the right ankle in a circular motion with the flat of the hands as in Figure 28 b.



a.



b.

Figure 28 - Ankles Massage -- Steps a. and b.

Rub the ankles vigorously. Again, if done correctly you will feel heat in the areas being massaged.

End the massage by tapping lightly along the entire length of each leg. Use the back of the hands for the inner side and the heel of the palms for the outer side.

7. Stretching Technique

End the massage with a stretching technique. Sit straight with the legs extended and breathe in through the nose. As you breathe out through the mouth, bend forward until you can touch or grasp the toes. Roll the backbone forward in a gentle and continuous motion. Try to bend from the pelvic region, keeping the spine fairly straight and the chest open. Do not crunch the chest down into the organs.

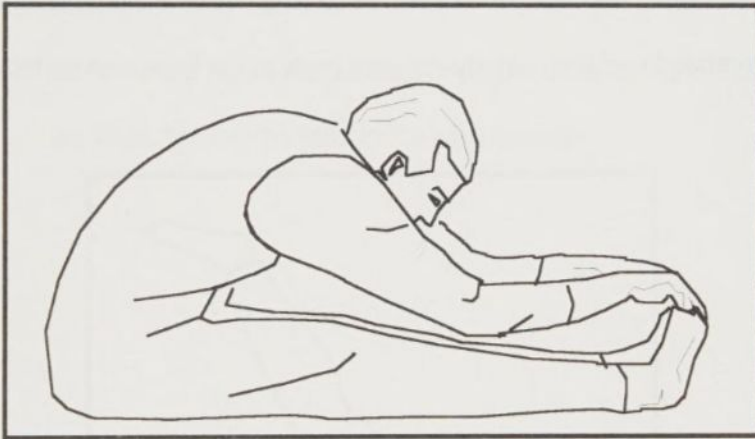


Figure 29 - Stretching

Spend about three minutes doing each of these techniques. When you massage the body and the legs, you should do it long enough to feel heat in the areas being massaged. This is especially true for the knee massage.



More details about the benefits of massage can be found in the book, "Self Healing Internal Exercises," recommended in the bibliography.

Note: You should not feel pain at any time during the massage.

8. Yoga Technique

I usually supplement the massage with a yoga technique called *Viparita Karani Mudra*. It is an inverse *asana* in which the lower part of the body is positioned above the upper part. It is relatively easy to execute and can be held for a long time.

Lie down flat on your back and lift the legs overhead as you breathe in. The hands are positioned on the lower back in order to support the weight of the legs held above. Since the legs are up, more blood flows into the upper body and benefits the upper body circulation, especially the head. In coming out of this *asana*, bring the knees close to the forehead and then **slowly** roll your back to the floor, one vertebra at a time.

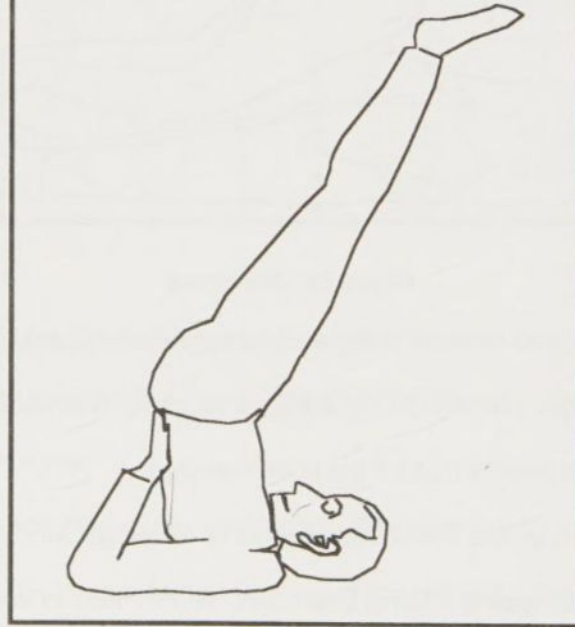


Figure 30 - Viparita Karani Mudra

Additional Points

1. Do not lift the head off the floor. Press the hands against the floor to control rolling the back as you get out of this asana.
2. I found this asana to be helpful in preventing colds, and if I already have a cold Viparita Karani Mudra can reduce the time necessary to get well. I usually spend about five minutes in Viparita Karani Mudra and a little longer if I have a cold.
3. People with high blood pressure or other ailments should check with their doctor before trying this asana.



More details about the benefits of yoga can be found in the book, "Light on Yoga," recommended in the bibliography.



9. Energy Balancing Technique

In order to equalize the blood pressure after Viparita Karani Mudra, you should end your routine with an energy-balancing technique.

The left hand grasps the forehead and lifts the head enough for the right hand to position itself under the head. Then rest the left hand on the forehead and relax in this position. As you keep the right hand under the head, slide the left hand successively to the throat, chest, solar plexus and lower abdomen. Relax in each of these positions for at least 30 seconds.



Figure 31 - Energy Balancing

Note: Do not lift the left hand off the body as you move it from one position to another. Instead, slide the left hand along the forehead, the throat, the chest, the solar plexus and the lower abdomen.

10. Relaxation

Lie down with your back flat on the floor. Tense all the muscles of the body for about 30 seconds with the legs, arms and head slightly raised off the floor. Then suddenly release all tension, allowing the legs, arms and head to drop back to the floor and relax. Repeat the sequence three times, tension followed by relaxation.

Afterwards rest for a while. Let yourself feel the heaviness in your hands and feet. Let them melt into the ground. Imagine yourself being a white, fluffy cloud floating in the sky. The cloud becomes a warm, summer rain that is quickly absorbed by the soil.



Nothing is left but the blue sky. You are one with the sky: empty, but at the same time containing everything.

Additional Points

1. Do not block the breath during relaxation.
2. Tension is followed abruptly by relaxation; let your limbs fall inertly to the floor. It is like cutting the string of a bow: the wooden part changes its shape suddenly to reclaim its original form.

11. Application of Massage Techniques for Health

You should use the massage techniques described above, keeping in mind your current condition of health. For example:

- If you have lower back pain, you should do more lower back massage (see page 54).
- If you have a running nose, you should do more nose massage (see page 46) and spend more time in Viparita Karani Mudra (see page 60).
- If you have eye problems, you should do more eye massage (see page 45).
- If you have stomach problems, you should do more abdomen circular massage, lower abdomen massage, solar plexus massage and stomach massage (see pages 50, 51, 52 and 53).
- If you have leg, hip, knee or ankle problems, you should do more leg, hip, knee and ankle massage (see pages 55, 56, 57 and 58).
- If you have a low flexibility, you should warm up more (see page 35) and do more stretching (see page 59).
- If you have a low level of energy, you should do more sole massage (page 36).
- When you are stressed, the face muscles get easily tensed. The face massage is useful in eliminating any tension accumulated in the body (see page 45). The face massage comes in handy wherever you are: at work, in school, in the subway, etc.
- If after the face massage you still feel stressed, you can increase the overall massage time and spend more time in relaxation (see page 63).



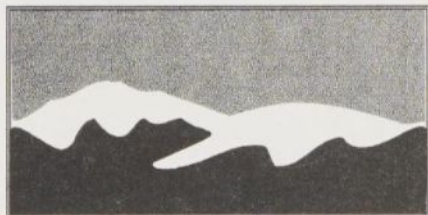
Over time, our meditation practice goes through several stages and each one brings its own fruits to help us stay on the path.

First Stage - Stillness

As we become used to meditation, we get physical and mental balance. We begin to feel like a Buddha carved in stone, immovable like a mountain.

The quality that emerges after reaching the first stage is:

STILLNESS



When we master stillness, we realize that all things come and go, life itself comes and goes. We are visitors on this planet. Everything is impermanent except the awareness that existed before the world was born.

65

Riding the Dragon

Second Stage - Detachment

As stillness becomes more of a second nature to us, we begin to feel our "soul's cup" being filled with contentment and happiness.

After meditation has fed our roots, the quality that emerges is:

DETACHMENT



Detachment in the Taoist understanding does not mean living your life in seclusion, like a monk in a monastery, away from the world. Detachment means living in society, but not being taken away by its distractions. It means taking it easy and not becoming frustrated with all of life's inevitable problems. You are in the midst of the events but you look at them from the outside, like a witness.

66

Meditation Stages

Third Stage - Quietness

After years and years of practice, we feel a deep silence in meditation that impregnates every particle of our body. After we achieve the stillness of the body, we now also get the quietness of the mind.

The quality that emerges is:

QUIETNESS



When the mind becomes quiet, we feel integrated with the universe. On the Oracle of Delphi it is written, "Gnoti se auto." It means, "Know yourself."

Only when the mind is quiet, can we learn something about ourselves. We learn that we are not only body and mind. We have a body and a mind that are our tools to interact with the outside world, but we no longer identify ourselves with them. We realize that we are pure awareness.

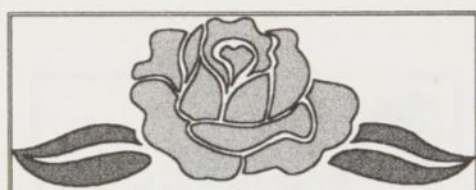
67

Fourth Stage - Wisdom

We feel our being is light, like a bubble floating in the blue sky: empty, but at the same time containing everything.

The quality that emerges is:

WISDOM



Wisdom is the ability to live in the present moment; it means living our life consciously. The Romans used to say, "Hic et nunc." It means, "Here and now."

Live your life here and now because here and now is the only time in your life that you can do something about, the only time when you can make decisions and change your attitude.

We also develop an optimistic outlook that good things are bound to happen in our life. We look "on the brighter side" and even difficult problems can help us to mature inwardly.

Over the years, a subtle change happens in our thinking: we develop the ability to learn from our mistakes. I have often seen my friends making the same mistakes over and over again. They get hurt but they do not learn from them. When we can learn from our mistakes, we start to grow both rationally and emotionally.

Through the practice of meditation, not only the body but also the mind become more flexible. We gain the ability to adjust faster to changes in our relationships. We also learn how to yield when confrontations happen. We are alive and awake, ready to "roll with the punches." We become a person rooted in awareness and compassion, we become a "real person."

Now, we should not expect to get through the meditation stages right away. In fact, do not expect anything, just carry on with your daily meditation routine (day after day, week after week, year after year). When the apple is ripe, it falls from the tree of its own accord.



In the same way, when you are ready, these experiences will come to you automatically. Keep in mind that everybody is different. You can go through different stages at different speeds, but this does not make your experiences more or less valuable.

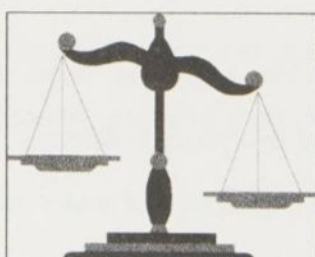
It could happen that one day you sit in meditation and you experience an intense feeling of happiness like a sparkling comet which envelops you as well as the whole universe. It vibrates in every particle of your body and you feel like a scorched land after a spell of drought has finally received its share of rain.

The mind may now have a natural tendency to wish for pleasure and to run away from pain (this is one way the survival mechanism works). Though beneficial most of the time, this mechanism can become a hindrance in your meditation practice. For example, you may begin your practice with the desire to enjoy the blissful experiences you had before. But this desire is working against the very goal of Taoist meditation, which is to empty the mind.

Be careful, do not fall into the trap of having expectations from your meditation practice. Otherwise, you will no longer be able to let go of your thoughts and you may become frustrated to the point of giving up meditation completely!

What is important is constancy in your practice; rather than doing a long meditation occasionally, you are better off doing half an hour of meditation every day.

Also, remember that every day is a new day. Like a scale, your meditation practice goes up and down.



Advanced Breathing Techniques

In order to become more aware of your breathing, place the index and the middle finger of the left hand in the lower Tan Tien area, as in **Figure 11 a**. Then practice the following techniques:

First Level - Deep Breathing Exercises

1. Breathe in through the nose slowly and deeply and as you breathe out through the mouth, say the sound **Ooo** (as in hope). It should feel as if the sound is coming from the lower Tan Tien and not from the vocal cords. Repeat about 10 times. Then take a few deep regular breaths.
2. Breathe in through the nose slowly and deeply and as you breathe out through the mouth, say the sound **Hoe** (as in herds). It should feel as if the sound is coming from the lower Tan Tien, rather than from the vocal cords. Repeat about 10 times. Then take a few deep regular breaths.

Second Level - Rapid Breathing Exercises

3. As you breathe in through the nose (some air will escape), say the sound **Hing** ("h" as in horse and "ing" as in king) forcefully, and as you breathe out through the mouth, say the sound **Ha** (as in hop). Again, it should feel as if the sound is coming from the lower abdomen, rather than from the vocal cords (say them in a deep voice).

Repeat rapidly about 20 to 30 times. After the last **Hing-Ha**, keep breathing out until you empty the lungs. Then breathe normally again.

4. In the beginning you should only practice the deep breathing exercises (first level) for about six months; then, you may start the rapid breathing exercises (second level).

If you are only doing the deep breathing exercises or you are also doing the rapid breathing exercises, conclude your breathing techniques with the sound **Aum**. Breathe in through the nose slowly and deeply and as you breathe out through the mouth, say the sound **Aum** (as in omega). It should feel as if the sound is coming from the lower Tan Tien, rather than from the vocal cords. Repeat about 10 times. Then take a few deep regular breaths.

The *Brahman* belief is that the sound **Aum** is at the root of the universe and that it has the miraculous power of bringing forth all living things.



The sound **Aum** is also a mantra frequently used in yoga meditation, and it is very helpful for calming the mind. If you have practiced the rapid breathing exercises intensely, it will also help to calm the breath and give you some respite.

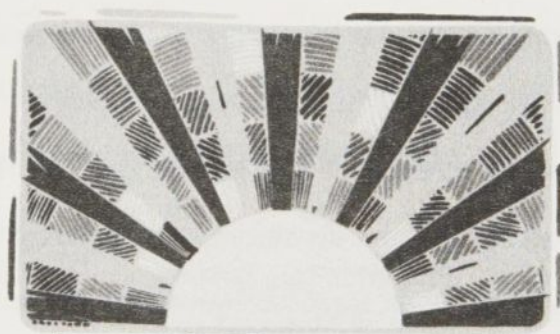
Additional Points

- a. While practicing the deep breathing exercises, the key to feeling heat in the lower Tan Tien is breath control. The breathing has to be very long and smooth, either when breathing in or when breathing out, to obtain the full benefits of these exercises.
- b. When you breathe in (**Hing**), tighten the muscles around the anus and draw them in and up. If done correctly, it feels as if the entire anal area is being drawn in and upward. It is like closing a valve.
- c. When you breathe out (**Ha**), relax the muscles around the anus. It is like opening a valve.
- d. The emphasis during the **Hing-Ha** breathing is to push the air straight down toward the lower Tan Tien (the **Hing** part of the respiration -- breathing in).
- e. These techniques help us to sink the chi into the lower Tan Tien (also called the cauldron). We feel heat rising up from the abdomen into the whole body. We may even perspire during this practice. At an advanced level we can start to circulate this energy through the Small Orbit (see Glossary). The Taoists call the process through which we become more energetic, "the cultivation of chi."

Note: You have to be able to generate this energy in the first place; then, you can consider circulating it through the Small Orbit. If you only imagine feeling heat and then try to circulate it, you will end up with a headache.

- f. It is advisable to add these techniques as a supplement at the end of the second meditation step (breathing deeply).

g. These techniques help us to become more quiet inside; accordingly, it becomes easier to meditate.



Integration of Taoist Meditation into Daily Life

The best time to practice meditation is early in the morning, around 5 a.m., on an empty stomach. This is the time when everything is quiet, it's still dark outside and the air is fresh. It's a propitious moment.

It's important to meditate in a safe, quiet environment, away from distractions. Turn off the telephone and let the answering machine take messages for you. Shut the windows so the street noise cannot distract you. In summer turn on the air conditioning unit so the air in the room is cool and pleasant and you can last in meditation for a long time. Use a radio-alarm to wake you up from meditation gently and avoid the shock of an alarm clock. Ask the other members of your family to avoid disturbing you when you are in meditation so that you can fully relax.

If you feel tired during meditation, the best thing to do is to go to sleep and meditate later, when rested. Meditation, when practiced correctly, induces a state of trance that is like dreamless sleep. After half an hour of meditation, I often feel renewed as if I had slept several hours.

The saying, "Thank God, it's Friday!" shows how we live our lives. People live waiting for the weekend and when it finally arrives they cannot unwind to enjoy it. But with meditation we can relax, smile and enjoy life rather than fight it.

Meditation slows down the anxiety arising in daily life. It brings us back to ourselves in a way which helps us to be more focused in our activities. We acquire a certain quietness and we enjoy increased self-control over our emotions.

It is written in the "Katha Upanishad,"

"When one lacks discrimination
and his mind is undisciplined, the senses
run hither and thither like wild horses.
But they obey the reins like trained horses
when one has discrimination and has made
the mind one-pointed."



Because it is difficult to meditate when you are tired, I usually use Reiki with meditation. Reiki is a Japanese technique used for relaxation and also for energizing the body.



More information about Reiki can be found in the book, "Reiki: Universal Life Force Energy," recommended in the bibliography.

It is ideal to practice Reiki when you go to bed so that you can relax and sleep better. Accordingly, I do about one hour of meditation in the morning and about half an hour of Reiki when I go to bed.

I would like to emphasize that meditation works much better when it is practiced together with Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung.

Tai Chi Chuan is an internal *Kung Fu* system. *Kung Fu* means fighting skill. An internal fighting system is a system where the emphasis lies on the speed of execution and the strength of the punches or kicks comes mainly from the proper body alignment. An external *Kung Fu* system is a fighting system where the emphasis lies on physical strength and the student memorizes a sequence of attacks and defenses.

In Tai Chi Chuan you let your opponent attack first and you only counterattack. This is very difficult and the main reason the study of Tai Chi Chuan takes so many years to master.

Tai Chi Chuan is famous for being practiced in slow motion, but this is deceiving. When you start learning Tai Chi Chuan, you practice in slow motion so that you learn the positions correctly; later on, you practice both slowly and quickly. Like driving a car, you want to be able to change the speed of training at will.

A major difference between Tai Chi Chuan and Western-style sports like soccer or basketball is that after playing Tai Chi Chuan you feel rejuvenated and quite rested, but after playing soccer or basketball you feel exhausted. Thus, Tai Chi Chuan, like meditation and Nei Kung, works on conserving and replenishing the body's energy. I do not suggest that you should give up Western-style sports; they are fun. However, if you feel tired and you need a tune-up, Tai Chi Chuan is definitely a better choice.

Torn ligaments, bruised tendons, sprained ankles and broken bones, that often happen in Western sports, are not common in Tai Chi Chuan. On the contrary, Tai Chi

Riding the Dragon

Chuan strengthens the ligaments, the tendons, the joints and the bones.

Nei Kung is an internal complex of exercises, several thousand years old, practiced to increase the body's vital energy, chi. Internal exercises increase chi in a calm and relaxed manner as in a meditation. Some Nei Kung positions like "*Embrace Horse*" or "*Play Pi Pa*" resemble a yoga asana. You stand in the position for about 20 minutes without moving. Through proper body alignment, the energy flows freely in the body, and after the training you feel rejuvenated and strong.



More information about Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung can be found in "The Book of Nei Kung" and "T'ai Chi Ch'uan Principles and Practice," recommended in the bibliography.

In the morning I start with meditation. Next, I do about 10 minutes of Nei Kung and 20 minutes of Tai Chi Chuan. When I have extra time available, I do *Push Hands* and fighting techniques.



If you do not have enough time to do them all in the morning, you can do meditation in the morning and shift the practice of Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung to the evening. Notice that I increase the speed of training gradually. First, I sit in meditation to quiet the mind, then I do Nei Kung to fill the body with energy and then I play Tai Chi

Chuan to circulate the energy in the body. At the end I do fighting techniques that are executed at a fast pace.

We practice Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung in the same way as we practice meditation, that is, by letting go. Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung and meditation are the three jewels of the Chinese culture and all spring from Taoism.

The Romans had a similar idea concerning the importance of body and mind, when they said, "Men sana in corpore sano." It means, "A healthy mind living in a healthy body." Accordingly, you should incorporate not only meditation but also Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung in your daily practice.

Nei Kung, Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation each play a different role in the cycle of energy. Nei Kung works mostly on generating energy while Tai Chi Chuan works mostly on circulating this energy. Taoist meditation, however, works primarily on storing the energy in the body, particularly in the lower Tan Tien area.

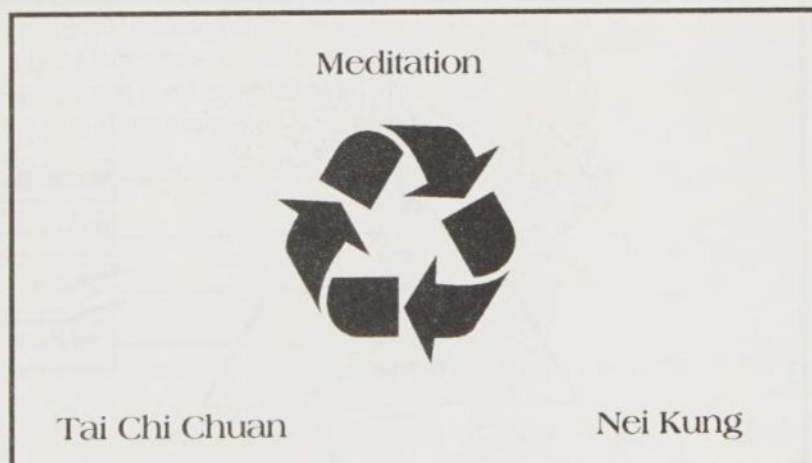


Figure 32 - The Energy Cycle

After 40 our body's metabolism slows down. Therefore, it becomes even more important to stay fit. If practiced daily, meditation, Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung can help us feel young even in our old age. In China many old people practice meditation, Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung for health.

The Taoists discovered four levels of human energy: *ching*, *chi*, *shen* and *hun*. Ching is raw energy extracted from food and air. Ching is transformed by the body into *chi*. *Chi* is the energy used to perform physical activities. If there is plenty of *chi*, some is transformed into *shen*. *Shen* is mostly used in mental activities. The most refined form of energy is *hun*. *Hun* is the universal energy that pervades all things.

Nei Kung, Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation work on different levels of energy. Nei Kung helps the body to generate *ching*. Tai Chi Chuan works on transforming *ching* into *chi*. Taoist meditation helps in refining *chi* into *shen* and *hun*.

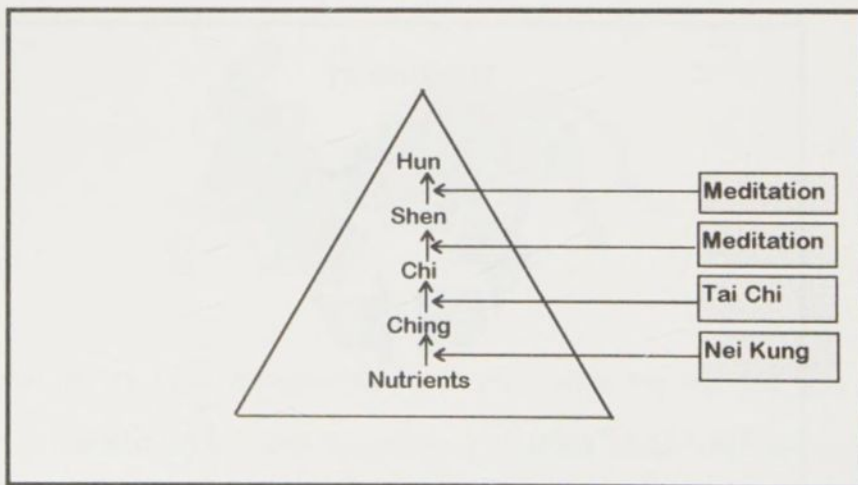


Figure 33 - The Energy Pyramid

A key element in the study of any martial art is self-discipline. Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung and Taoist meditation are no exception. If you are not disciplined, it is not possible to learn anything in depth. But on the other side, you should not take your practice too seriously.

My master says: "Do it like you do not care." This means to show constancy and purpose in your training, but if one day you do not have enough time to practice, it is still all right. Be flexible, smile and try to relax and have fun.

The same lesson that I learned from *Sifu*, Krishna taught Arjuna before going to war in the famous Indian saga, Bhagavad-Gita,

"Having gained equanimity in pleasure and pain, in gain and in loss, in victory and defeat, then come out to fight."

Come out to fight means do whatever you have to do, but perform actions with equanimity of spirit,

"The wise, their intellect truly united with the Self, having renounced the fruits born from their actions and being liberated from the bonds of birth, arrive at a state devoid of suffering."



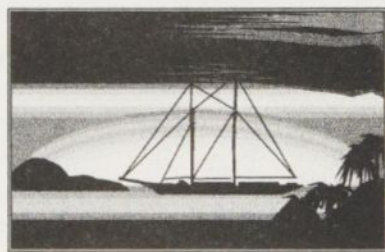
Riding the Dragon

From detachment arises steadfastness,

"He whose mind is unshaken in the midst of sorrows, who amongst pleasures is free from longing, from whom attachment, fear and anger have departed, he is said to be a sage of steady intellect."

The key words in these verses are "steady intellect." This is one of the goals of Taoist meditation: to help us to be less affected by emotions and passions and to help us to become rooted in ourselves so that no "wind" can overcome us easily,

"When a man completely casts off all desires that have gone (deep) into the mind, O Partha, when he is satisfied in the Self through the Self alone, then he is said to be of steady intellect."



Sometimes we overestimate the importance of minor incidents. When you become aware of this, try to make an effort to pull back and look at the "big picture." Do not let things get to you! This applies not only in daily life but also in the practice of Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung and meditation. If you are too serious in your routine, it will become difficult to relax and let go and that defeats the whole purpose of meditation.

We need to have a standard for checking successful meditation. Assume that you decide to meditate for half an hour. If you feel that it takes forever to complete your

meditation, then your skill is on a low level; however, if half an hour has passed before you have noticed it, your skill is on a high level (provided you are not asleep!).



Another sign that shows that your meditation is making progress is when you become able to ignore noise in the environment. I do not mean a car alarm, because this is too difficult to ignore. But if you can ignore street noise, the TV in another room, the telephone ringing and so on, then your meditation becomes rooted in silence.



It feels like a screen that rises between you and the rest of the world, and the noise slowly vanishes as you sink deeper and deeper into meditation. This is the way to meditate as described in "Questions and Answers by Chen Wei Ming,"

Riding the Dragon

"Sit down with the legs crossed, the head as suspended from above, the coccyx straight, the two eyelids dropped and the hands folded in front of the belly. In short, close all five senses: close the eyes and do not see out, close the ears and do not listen, close the mouth and do not talk, close the nose and do not smell, close the mind and do not think....ears, eyes, mouth, nose and mind -- all return to their original order. Then you are able to see heaven's heart and the spirit will come to you automatically (you will have a godlike awareness)."



Nutrition

In my experience, a vegetarian diet makes it easier to meditate because you feel as light as a feather, and can empty the mind faster. However, it can be difficult and time-consuming to keep a balanced vegetarian diet with plenty of proteins. After several years on a vegetarian diet, I had to eat some meat for medical reasons.

I try to have fish or chicken once or twice a week and occasionally beef. But I eat meat in small quantities and with plenty of vegetables. Also, I try to eat a wide variety of foods and eat only fresh food. I stay away from junk or canned food.



If you have a sweet tooth, try to eat natural products such as honey, figs, dates, cantaloupe, watermelon, mango and papaya, rather than candy or ice cream.

85

Riding the Dragon

It is important to eat mindfully, paying full attention to what we eat and chewing carefully. Eating mindfully helps prevent overeating because it gives us time to feel when we have had enough. In eating less we gain more.

If you are not hungry, do not eat. If you have a lot of time available and you do not know what to do with it, by all means do not fill it with food (or sex). Wait until you are really hungry, then eating (or making love) will fulfill a biological and emotional need, rather than a fantasy of the mind. In this way you will enjoy life more and you will probably live longer.

When you eat, give yourself time, do not rush, keep your mind on the food and try not to talk too much. In time, you will learn to feel which foods your body needs and be able to eat in moderation, rather than eating only for taste but with little nutritional value. Good nutrition helps our overall well-being and you should give it the importance it deserves.

Note : Do not read the newspaper or watch TV while eating!



86

Application of Taoist Meditation in Martial Arts

When you are sparring, you need focus. If you worry about what you are going to have for dinner, you will get punched. Therefore, you need to let go of your daily worries in order to be able to fight successfully. Tai

Chi Chuan fighting has one major principle,

“Four ounces can deflect one thousand pounds.”

This means that we do not oppose force with force. You let your opponent attack you with all his might and you yield. This strategy reminds us of the *Yin and Yang Symbol*.



Figure 34 - Yin and Yang Symbol

When my opponent's attack is hard (yang), my response is soft (yin) and I get away. When my opponent's attack is soft and hesitant (yin), my response is hard and decisive (yang). Yin follows yang and yang follows yin. The Tai Chi Chuan strategy emulates the cycle of the seasons. It is the never-ending wheel of changes that keeps the universe alive.

87

When the mind is quiet, you react faster so that you can allow your opponent to attack first. In Taoist meditation you learn the skill of calming the mind. When you can do so, you automatically react to your opponent's attack; accordingly, you will be faster than him. Then your Tai Chi Chuan fighting skill develops to a high level as described in the "Art of War,"

"Know yourself and know your opponent.
You can start your attack after your opponent starts his,
but reach him before he reaches you."

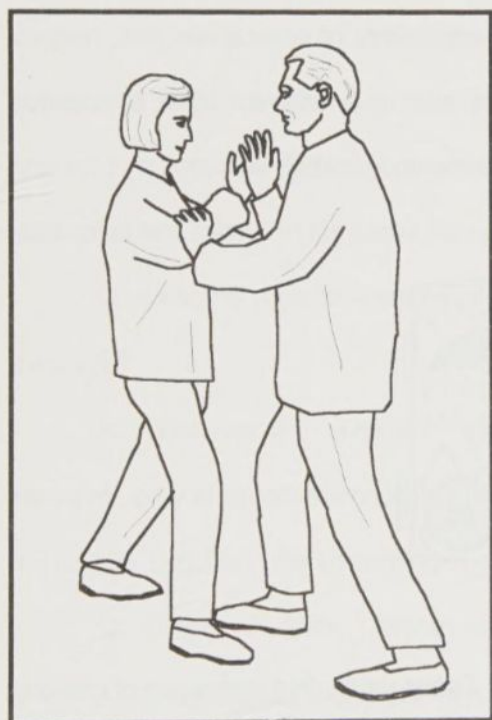
From Tai Chi Chuan emerged Push Hands. Push Hands is a unique sparring exercise in which the two partners develop the skill of deflecting punches using a minimum amount of physical strength. Push Hands often involves using your opponent's power to gain advantage in fighting.



In Push Hands each partner gets a chance to attack and to defend himself. Each takes turns, so while one opponent is attacking the other one is defending himself and then they reverse their roles. The attacking partner does not yield (is hard), while the defending partner wards off by shifting the body weight back and twisting (is soft). It is important to remember that the person who defends himself, while yielding, has to

maintain the roundness of his body. Especially the forward arm, which protects the center of the body, remains soft until a certain point in the defense. If your opponent is pressing very hard, rather than bending the elbow more, the whole upper body twists in one piece.

There are two kinds of Push Hands: One-Hand Push Hands and Two-Hands Push Hands. While One-Hand Push Hands trains the practitioner in the art of feeling the opponent's intentions, Two-Hands Push hands gets closer to real combat.



Two-Hands Push Hands



One-Hand Push Hands

Figure 35 - Push Hands

Notice that when you are playing Push Hands you empty your mind of any anticipation that your opponent is going to attack you in any specific way and of any

expectation that you will defeat your opponent in any specific way. You just wait, like a big cat waiting for its prey, for your opponent to show a gap in concentration and then you make your move quickly and decisively.

While waiting for an opportunity to attack, try to feel your opponent's center. It is to his center that you will aim your attack because the center is the most difficult zone of the body to defend. Also, while you are playing Push Hands, do not break the contact between you and your opponent.

Push Hands teaches us how to adjust to opponents of various weights, heights and temperaments. Later on, we can use this skill at a different level because it becomes easier to adjust to changes of fortune so common in daily life.



Like Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands uses the Taoist meditation technique of calming the mind in order to be able "to listen to your opponent's *ging*" -- to feel your opponent's strong and weak points and to get away when you are attacked.



More information about martial arts can be found in the book, "T'ai Chi Ch'uan Principles and Practice," recommended in the bibliography.

Questions and Answers

Q

uestion: You speak about emptying the mind, but if you empty the mind how do you know that you do not think?

Answer: When you are hungry, you feel hunger and when you are full, you feel full. In the same way, when you empty your mind you know that you do not think and when you worry you know that you worry. The mind and the body are not two separate entities, but rather one continuum. With practice, you will control your mind and relax it in the same way you can relax your muscles.

Q: In some yoga techniques people focus on the third eye. Do you focus on the third eye?

A: Yes, we do. The third eye, in Chinese, is called the upper Tan Tien. However, only at an advanced level should we shift the focus from the lower Tan Tien to the middle Tan Tien (the solar plexus) and later on to the upper Tan Tien (the third eye).

Q: When I meditate, I cannot sit still. Is this a problem?

A: Meditation is sitting still with a quiet mind. Thus, you should first master the posture and become able to sit still, and later you can work on emptying the mind.

Q: In some yoga techniques, in meditation, people close their eyes. Do you close the eyes in Taoist meditation?

A: Yes, we do. But in the beginning we meditate with the eyes slightly open. This makes it easier to focus during the first five steps and to let go in the last step.

At an advanced level we can meditate either with the eyes wide open or with the eyes completely closed.

Q: When I sit for a long time in Lotus my legs get numb. What should I do?

A: This happens in the beginning. Later in your development the numbness should go away and you will feel quite comfortable in this posture. In Lotus, the blood circulation in the legs is reduced and hence the blood circulation in the rest of the body is increased.

Q: How do you manage to stay cheerful throughout the day?

A: I learned the secret by observing my son. Now and then we like to play soccer together in a courtyard in the neighborhood. When Johnny falls and hurts himself, he cries. But when the pain is gone he is happy again and he has completely forgotten his tears.



I try to do the same. When I am sick I feel miserable, but the moment I am well again I let all memories of pain go away. I do not carry the burden of past sufferings with me. Why should I? By living in the present moment, we get more out of life effortlessly.

Q: Why is this method called Taoist meditation?

A: We call it Taoist meditation because it comes from the Taoist tradition. This technique springs from the description of meditation as it was handed down to us by Master Chen Wei Ming in his treatise, "Questions and Answers by Chen Wei Ming."

Q: I expected that meditation would help me to become perfectly detached. When I realized that I failed to achieve my goal, I gave up meditation altogether. What do you think about this?

A: Only stones are perfectly detached. People love and hate, people become attached to things and when they lose them they suffer. Setting unrealistic expectations in your meditation can only slow your progress.

The practice of meditation on a daily basis will help you to become more detached and less afraid of life. We live in a continuum between tension and relaxation and decreasing the friction that occurs in daily life can make a big difference. Setting realistic goals can help you to master yourself.

Q: Can I listen to music while I meditate?



A: The goal of meditation is to empty the mind so you can renew yourself. When you listen to music, feelings and thoughts arise and it becomes very difficult to let go. But you can listen to music during the warm-up and during the massage techniques. In fact, listening to music during massage makes it easier to relax the body. I suggest a soft, gentle music for this purpose like "Melodies of Japan" by James Galway.

Q: When I look in the mirror, I notice that I am getting older. Can meditation help me stay young?

A: Like a flower, the body is like a bud in spring; in summer it blossoms and in fall it withers. You cannot help it; yet meditation helps maintain the body and mind at the optimal performance. Also, through the practice of meditation you become more detached. You no longer identify yourself with the body and mind. Like a witness, you observe the changes of the body without becoming too upset. You smile at yourself and smile at the world. You become content with your life even though you are aging.

Q: Although I practice meditation, Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung I still feel tired quite often. What is the reason that I feel depleted of energy?

A: Energy or chi is like money. You can make a lot of money and still go bankrupt. If you spend more money than you make, sooner or later you will end up "in the red." Meditation, Tai Chi Chuan and Nei Kung will help you to feel more energetic. But if you spend too much energy, for example, in sexual activities, you will end up exhausted. I am not preaching abstinence, but I emphasize moderation. Be careful not to fall to the other extreme either. If you are too concerned about how to save your energy, you may end up spending a lot of energy worrying how to save your energy. Again, the key word is moderation. As with money, you spend your energy but it is best to save some too, so that eventually you will be able to transform this energy to higher levels (see Figure 33).



Q: There are other meditation methods. How do I know that Taoist meditation is the best one for me?

A: You do not know. Do not accept any meditation unconditionally, but do not reject it blindly either. Use your common sense in examining each one and then select a method that best fits your needs.

Q: What is the reason for smiling during meditation?

A: The smile helps to relax the whole body. When we start to meditate, this smile is a little bit forced, it is only on the outside. Nevertheless, if we learn to smile our thoughts develop a more optimistic pattern and it becomes easier to face life and enjoy it. It becomes easier to sit still and meditate. Also, smiling during meditation is a good practice for smiling in daily life.

When we get deeper into meditation, a different smile blossoms on our face. It comes from inside and is associated with a deep relaxation of the whole body and a feeling of detachment and happiness. It is like nothing can be added or removed from us. We are content the way we are and somehow we feel that we always have been like that.



Riding the Dragon

Meditation cultivates a special attitude toward life. You no longer fight all the "battles." You learn how to yield. When confrontations happen, you let others feel victorious. You may lose some "battles," but you win the "war." The war is your life and what you win is peace of mind. You get to enjoy your life more. You smile at yourself and you smile at the world. You have arrived. Finally, you are "home."



Q: Though my father passed away a long time back, I still feel anger toward him. Can meditation help?

A: Your father wasn't always so mean and intransigent. There was a time when our parents were children like us and they were hurt by their parents. People do not become rude overnight. Parents do their best for their children, but maybe because our parents were deprived of the love they needed to grow up emotionally, they didn't know how to bestow love on us.

Try to make peace with your father and one day you will understand that making peace with him is making peace with yourself. Our parents live in us in the same way we live in our children.

Through the practice of meditation you cultivate understanding and acceptance of other people. Your father is more significant to you than other people and by understanding him and the circumstances in which he lived you will begin to understand and accept yourself and your own shortcomings. Resentment toward your father is like a heavy burden that you have been carrying for a long time, although you were not always aware of it. Try to let it go and you will feel 1,000 pounds lighter.

Q: I play Tai Chi Chuan and I also do yoga, karate, tennis and swimming. Is this good for me?



A: Of course, you can practice all these disciplines and each of them has its own merits. However, you should find out which one of them is best for you and focus mostly on it. In this way, you will be able to reap more benefits. Rather than spreading yourself in many places, you will get more by studying one discipline in depth.

Q: Sometimes I have a hard time when I have to make a difficult decision. Can meditation help me to resolve indecision?

A: Indecision is not necessarily bad; on the contrary, it can help you to maintain balance in life. For instance, say your friend is asking you to lend him a lot of money. Common sense may tell you that he is asking for too much, but on the other hand you want to help him because he is your friend, so there is a conflict.

My master used to say, "First help yourself, then help the others."

Riding the Dragon

What you may want to do is to strike a balance, lend him some money, but do not use all your resources. Help, but help in moderation -- learn how to compromise.

Looking deeply can help you see both sides of an issue and eventually you will resolve your problem.

Q: I just finished reading "Riding the Dragon" and it seems a little bit idealistic to me. How can I practically take advantage of all this information?

A: This book helps you to find a direction. It works like a magnetic needle, it points toward a horizon of detachment and conscious living. So during the day when you run into all kinds of problems and conflicts you remind yourself:

"I want to live gracefully and peacefully and I want to keep this awareness in mind even when problems confront me."

When this awareness does not seem to help, you can reinforce it with the help of deep breathing (a technique that you learned as part of the Taoist meditation). Accordingly, it becomes easier to maintain a pleasant attitude in life; however, "Riding the Dragon" is by no means a formula for sudden enlightenment.

Q: What is the difference between Tai Chi Chuan and Push Hands?

A: Suppose that you are taking a biology class. A good analogy to illustrate the difference between Tai Chi Chuan and Push Hands is that Tai Chi Chuan is the lecture portion of the class and Push Hands is the laboratory.

When you study Tai Chi Chuan you learn the "form." You may be more familiar with karate. The equivalent of the Tai Chi Chuan form is "kata" in karate.

Push Hands is a sparring exercise in which two partners develop the skill to withstand an attack by an opponent using a minimum amount of force and to

counterattack. At an advanced level, you learn *Walking Push Hands* and *Ta Lu* that get even closer to real fighting. The equivalent of Push Hands is "jukumite" in karate.

Q: Does Taoism give emphasis to sexual abstinence?

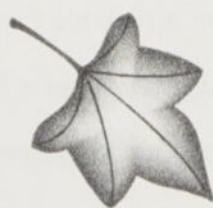
A: Sex is an integral part of living. It is also one of the joys of relationships, so why amputate your life? However, Taoism emphasizes moderation, as expressed in the phrase, "Use it, but do not abuse it!" You should exercise moderation not only in your sexual life, but also in eating, drinking, exercising, work and all other activities.

Q: Why is it so difficult for me to stop thinking during meditation?

A: The mind has a natural apprehension of losing control. Therefore, the last step of meditation -- letting go -- is very difficult. Only with perseverance and regular practice can you go beyond the barrier of the mind.

Q: What is the difference between Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung and Taoist meditation?

A: In Taoist meditation you follow a sequence of five steps in order to be able to empty your mind. In the sixth and last step you completely let go and enter true meditation (see page 43).



Nei Kung resembles Taoist meditation and therefore it is known as "standing" meditation. But Nei Kung positions are a lot more difficult to hold for a long period of time, so you can last in meditation much longer than in Nei Kung.

Riding the Dragon

Tai Chi Chuan is a martial art. When you play Tai Chi Chuan, rather than emptying the mind, you focus on the attacking hand or foot. Because it is usually taught and practiced in slow motion, Tai Chi Chuan is also known as "moving" meditation.

Also, Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung and Taoist meditation work on different levels of energy (see Figure 33 - The Energy Pyramid).

Q: Because of the weak economy, I am afraid that I might lose my job. Can Taoist meditation help me feel more secure?

A: Real security cannot be found outside oneself. There is no such thing as a perfectly secure job. It is true that some jobs are better than others, but still nothing is certain. Real security can only be found inside oneself. Only when you stop identifying yourself with the body and mind, can you get a glimpse of what real security is. Taoist meditation is a path that leads one toward true self-knowledge and away from daily anxiety.

Q: There are so many things I have started but so few things I have accomplished. I feel frustrated and I do not know what to do. Can you offer any advice that could help me?

A: We are not limitless. Lift a rock too heavy and you will get hurt. Try to study a whole book in one day and you will get a headache. Jump from a cliff and you will break your bones. Therefore, before making a commitment carefully assess the situation. Check if you have the needed resources and if the job can be done, by all means, proceed. Otherwise, you will only exhaust yourself trying to accomplish too many things and, in fact, getting nothing done.

Q: I gave my friend some advice but, to my surprise, he refused to listen to me.

What caused this attitude?

A: Be cautious when you offer advice. Accordingly, wait until your friend asks for advice or help. He will then welcome your support. Otherwise, do not intrude in somebody else's private life. By doing this, you will avoid some unpleasant moments.

You can only help somebody who wants your help and you can only teach somebody who wants to learn.

Q: I am afraid of losing my job and this makes me tense and nervous. Do

you have any advice that could help me?

A: If you have a problem, such as fear of losing your job, you will carry this problem with you no matter what the conditions are. Unless you face your fear you will not be able to slow down and live in the present moment. You have to understand that no job is ever safe and there is only so much control that you can have of your life. Hopefully, the practice of Taoist meditation and Tai Chi Chuan will give you more strength and self-confidence (you will become more rooted in the *Tao*) and will help you be more relaxed and pleasant both at work and at home (smiling as the day goes by).

Q: I am a student in college. I am usually quite relaxed before a test, but after entering the classroom I become nervous. What is the reason for this change?

A: When you enter the classroom you are no longer alone, but in the presence of your fellow students. Even though you are quite relaxed, the other students probably are not. Maybe it is their anxiety that makes you nervous. You interact with

people around you and what you feel is often the result of this interaction. It is difficult to be calm in the presence of a lot of anxious people.

You can try to breathe deeply and shift your attention to the lower Tan Tien (see the third step of the Taoist meditation on page 41). This technique can help you stay calm even in difficult circumstances.

Q: In the Western tradition the focus on personal development is in finding out who you really are. But in the Eastern tradition you are trying to run away from yourself by emptying the mind. Is this true?

A: This is not correct. It only seems that you are running away from yourself in the Eastern tradition. Actually, you are finding yourself both spiritually and physically. Only when you forget your daily worries, can you get in touch with your real Self. It may seem like a contradiction to you, but the best way to resolve this is to try meditation. Through the practice of meditation you get in touch with your real Self, beyond time and space.



Q: How come some people enjoy your classes and stick with meditation and Tai Chi Chuan for a long time, yet others quit after one or two lessons?

A: When a passerby hears the murmur of a brook, if he is thirsty he will stop and drink. Some people will like the taste of the water and stick with it for a long time, others will drink once or twice and follow their path, and some will not be thirsty at all. In all cases, the brook takes no offense.

I try not to attach too much importance to the fact that some students quit or that some students make progress a lot faster than others. Everybody is different. Like the brook, I simply try to be there for those students who want to learn more about the art of Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands, Nei Kung and Taoist meditation.

The classical Taoist symbol is water. Water, on its way downstream, seems weak and goes around obstacles, but when it reaches the sea nothing can stop it.

It is also true that many students come to my classes with the expectation to learn meditation or Tai Chi Chuan within a week or two. This is not possible. You need to dedicate yourself to the study of meditation or Tai Chi Chuan for a long time before you will be able to feel the benefits and beauty of this training.

Unfortunately, our society cultivates an attitude of instant gratification; however, for many people this approach only leads to premature failure. If you want to learn meditation or a martial art you have to give yourself time, but if you do so the rewards will show up even before you expect them.

Q: I noticed that in our class some people are a lot more flexible than I am. How can I be like them?

A: Everybody is different. Whether you learn Tai chi Chuan, Push Hands, Nei Kung or Taoist meditation, do not compare yourself with the other students. Some

people learn faster than others and some people are in a better physical shape than others. You can only look at your own progress. If you see a small improvement in yourself, it still makes a big difference.

Remember the fable about the turtle and the rabbit. Though much slower, in the end, the turtle won the race. Constancy in training is a lot more important than quick progress followed by boredom and abandonment. Carry on your practice and progress will show even before you expect it.

Q: When I first learned Taoist meditation, I could meditate for a long time, but now I no longer have the patience for it. Why?

A: The secret in training is to start with a short exercise period and to gradually increase the duration. If you meditate for a half hour or so, it could be too much for you and after a while you will feel bored and tired. Do not force yourself, but do not be afraid to push a little bit. Be sure to do some practice. The same approach stands true also for Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands and Nei Kung.



Q: During meditation I find it difficult to push the air down to the lower Tan Tien. Do you know any exercise that can help me learn to breathe with the diaphragm?

A: Like a flower, our body needs a lot of fresh air and sun. Otherwise it withers. Breathing with the diaphragm supplies the body with the air it needs to function properly.

To learn to breathe with the diaphragm you can try this easy exercise. Lie down on your back and place one hand on your chest and the other hand on the solar plexus. Place a cup (or any other object -- not too light, not too heavy, but stable) on your abdomen. Have a pillow under your head so you can monitor your hands as well as the cup. Now, try to push the air down to the lower Tan Tien. If done correctly, the hands should not move instead you should be able to see the cup moving slowly up and down.

The additional weight of the cup on your abdomen will make it easier for you to focus on the lower Tan Tien. If you breathe too fast the cup will fall, so this exercise will also remind you to breathe slowly. The hands' role is to make sure that you do not use the muscles of the chest or of the solar plexus when breathing.

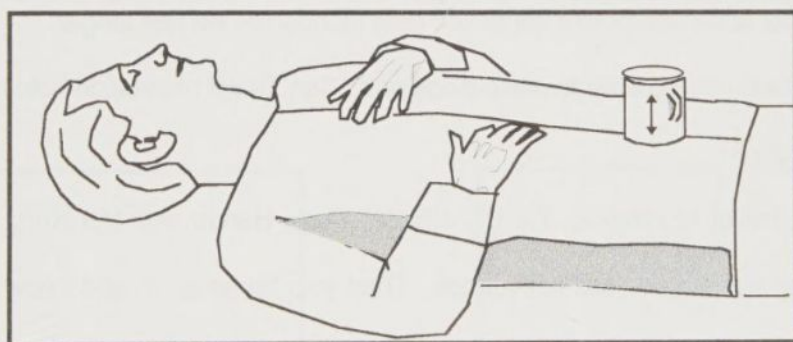


Figure 36 - Abdominal Breathing Exercise

Q: While I am learning Tai Chi Chuan, I am under the impression that I am not making progress quick enough. What do you think?

A: Let me tell you a story about how I learned Tai Chi Chuan. When I first started, if my master would not show me one or two new moves every time I went to the class, I felt frustrated and even felt that I was spending my money for nothing.

Three or four years later, I was still learning Tai Chi Chuan and one day my master asked me to show him the last move I was working on. Then he said,

"All right, let's go to the next move."

"Master," I replied, "if you do not mind, please show me the last move again, because I feel that I am not ready for the next one."

So you see, as you become more advanced you begin to understand that learning the form correctly is more important than rushing to learn a few new moves.

Q: I had only one good friend, but I felt disappointed by his behavior and I ended the relationship. Nowadays, I feel lonely. What should I do?

A: Try not to have too many expectations from others. Rather, focus on your own attitude. Do your best without expecting others to match your actions. In this way, you will suffer fewer disappointments and your friendships will last longer.

Q: I am often scared to make decisions. Can Taoist meditation help me become more assertive?

A: Taoist meditation, Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands and Nei Kung all help to cultivate self-esteem and self-confidence. Trust your "inner guru" and follow your heart. Make the best of this life and you will open up like a bud in spring.



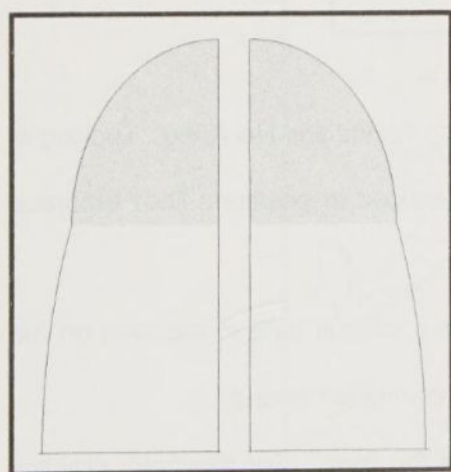
106

Questions and Answers

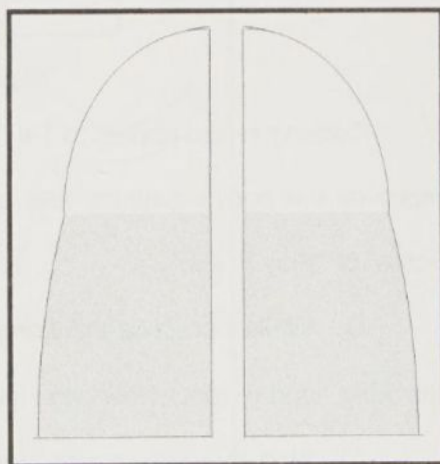
Q: Why does Taoist meditation emphasize breathing deeply?

A: The newborn baby breathes with the diaphragm (breathing deeply). Yet, somewhere down the line (I guess, in front of the TV) we lose this natural skill. So we need to retrain ourselves in order to be able to take full advantage of our lungs.

The anatomical structure of the lung resembles the shape of a cone. When you breathe using the chest's muscles, you mostly fill in the upper part of the cone. When you breathe using the diaphragm, you mostly fill in the lower part of the cone. The volume of the lower part of the cone is much bigger than the volume of the upper part. Accordingly, when you breathe using the diaphragm, a much larger quantity of air passes through the lungs. **Figure 37 a.** shows the lungs when you are breathing with the chest muscles. **Figure 37 b.** shows the lungs when you are breathing with the diaphragm.



a.



b.

Figure 37 - Abdominal Breathing Diagram -- Steps a. and b.

The shaded areas show the probable air intake. Breathing deeply also applies to Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands and Nei Kung.

Q: Do you tuck in during Taoist meditation?

A: When you sit in Lotus, you automatically tuck in. When the pelvis is tucked in, the lower back is straightened and this facilitates the circulation of energy, chi, in the body.



Figure 38 - Tucking in

Tucking in also applies to Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands and Nei Kung. Tucking in improves the body's balance and can easily be noticed in positions like "Embrace Horse" or "Play Pi Pa."

Q: While I practice the *Long Form*, I have a difficult time in focusing on the attacking hand or foot. How can I increase my concentration span?

A: Start by working only with a section of the form. For example, practice only the first part of the Long Form. Gradually your concentration will get better and you will be able to practice the whole form without being distracted.

Q: Which form is better to learn and practice: the Short or the Long Form?

A: You should learn both of them and practice according to the time available. When you have more time, practice the Long Form. However, when you are in a hurry, just practice the *Short Form* once or twice. It will still make your day feel better.

Nevertheless, keep in mind that in the Long Form the moves are better distributed. For example, a *Kick with the Heel* of the left foot is followed by a Kick with the Heel of the right foot. The same stands true for hand techniques. A *Brush Knee* with the left hand is followed by a Brush Knee with the right hand. Also, the link between moves feels smoother and more elegant. Therefore, in the long run, I believe that it is better to practice the Long Form. The Short Form will take no more than 15 minutes to complete, but will review only the basic Tai Chi Chuan moves.



Figure 39 - Kick with the Heel

Q: Can I meditate in the subway?

A: To be able to meditate, first you need to relax. It is much easier to relax in a safe environment, away from distractions, so you will gain more benefit if you practice at home or in a quiet and safe place.

Only at an advanced level and when you do not care that some mishaps could happen, should you meditate in the subway or in some other noisy and crowded place.

Q: I would like to learn Tai Chi Chuan but I am not sure that I can find a good teacher. What makes a good teacher?

A: A good teacher has to know well whatever he is teaching. A good Tai Chi Chuan teacher teaches according to the Tai Chi Chuan principles left to us by the old masters.



A good overview of those principles can be found in the book, "Tai Chi Chuan Principles and Practice," recommended in the bibliography.

But this is not enough. He needs to put his heart in the teaching. It is not difficult to tell the difference between an average teacher and a good one. Often an average teacher cannot wait until the lesson ends (he keeps looking at his watch) and

he may look bored to his students. On the contrary, a good teacher enjoys his subject. If a student has a question, the teacher takes extra time to clarify the answer.

Also, a good teacher has to put his actions where his mouth is. If he is teaching detachment but he is afraid of his own shadow, he is not a good example for his students. Instead, if there is harmony between a teacher's way of living and his lessons, then you know you can trust this person and learn from him.

Yet a good teacher is not enough. The student also needs to have a certain attitude if he is to learn Tai Chi Chuan or Taoist meditation well. He has to put his heart in whatever he is learning. If he only practices during the class, his progress will be very slow, if at all. But if the student enjoys the art of Tai Chi Chuan, he will use any free time for practice.

The Romans used to say, "Repetitum mater studiorum." It means, "Only through practice can you learn."

Once a student has found a good teacher, he has to trust him. He also needs to understand that his teacher is still a human being, and occasionally he can be wrong. But if he is to learn something from his teacher, rather than pointing out his teacher's mistakes, he should focus on learning the skill that his teacher can impart.



Riding the Dragon

When a student feels that he has mastered Tai Chi Chuan, he can start practicing on his own. Nevertheless, as long as he feels that he still needs directions from his teacher, he has to keep an open mind and be willing to learn. If a student thinks that he already knows Tai Chi Chuan, coming to classes means spending his time and money in vain. In fact, the more you know, the more you understand how little you know about the myriad of things that pervade the universe.



Q: I have a lot of negative thoughts rambling in my mind. Can Taoist meditation help me overcome this problem?

A: I also have negative thoughts once in a while. But I do not let them overwhelm me. The mind cannot focus on two things simultaneously. So when I become aware that I am experiencing negative images (and this is the first step to the solution), I shift my attention to my breathing and focus on the lower Tan Tien. I concentrate on my breathing until I have stopped and escaped from the cycle of negative thinking.

Taoist meditation trains the mind to work for you. The mind is like a car; you want to control the car by steering it, rather than closing your eyes and letting the car steer itself. Taoist meditation leads you on the path to self-mastery and detachment.

Q: What is the reason for sitting straight in meditation?

A: When you sit straight, the energy can flow freely in the body and therefore you can start to cultivate your chi. However, keep in mind that straight does not mean stiff. If your muscles are too tight, you may obstruct the flow of energy and you will not gain too much benefit from your meditation. What you want to do is to strike a balance. Sit neither tense nor limp rather, sit straight yet relaxed to enjoy your meditation.

By the way, the same idea stands true for the practice of Tai Chi Chuan, Push Hands and Nei Kung. All these disciplines require you to move (or to stand) in a relaxed, playful manner.

Q: Can I move my body during meditation?

A: Meditation is not some kind of torture where you cannot move under penalty of death. If you feel uncomfortable you can adjust your posture so it feels right for you. You should sit straight but relaxed, looking down (with eyelids almost closed) and slightly smiling. For more details refer to Prerequisites for Successful Meditation on page 29.

Q: When I started to practice Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation, I felt a sudden increase in my energy level. A year later, I cannot feel anything special although I practice these disciplines on a daily basis. What could be the reason?

A: If you cannot feel anything special, it does not mean that Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation do not help you feel better. It may be that in the beginning you were not used to the benefits of regular practice; therefore, it was easy for you to no-

Riding the Dragon

tice a marked increase in your energy level. However, after a while you became used to feeling more energetic, and it became harder to tell the difference between how you felt before you started your practice and how you feel now.

If you want to verify this explanation, you may wish to stop practicing for about two to four weeks (though I do not recommend it). Then, it is likely you will feel less energetic and you will gladly resume your practice to get back the benefits that Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation bring: increased agility and vitality, a good physical balance, and a clear mind possessed of detachment and grace.

Q: What is the reason for such a lack of awareness in the world?

A: The world's population is growing rapidly and so is the competition among people. In these circumstances our main pursuit is survival and little energy is left for higher conscious living. Therefore it becomes even more important to keep an oasis of silence within us. Tai Chi Chuan and Taoist meditation can help us make the best of our free time in this hectic society.



Q: I feel a continuous need to purchase something new. Once I acquire my new possession, after a short period of enjoyment, again I want to buy something else. Can Taoist meditation help me get rid of this habit?

A: The need for excitement is thoroughly cultivated in our society. The various media, the culture itself, are focused on the excitement that the new product will bring to the prospective owner. Values like constancy, understanding, patience and harmony are seldom heard of. You should become aware of this condition and not let the urge of desire overwhelm you. As written by Lao Tse in the "Tao Te Ching," try to,

"Weaken your ambitions,
Strengthen your essence."

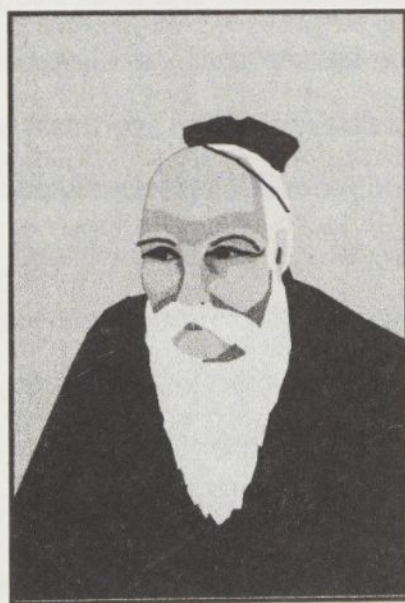


Figure 40 - Lao Tse

Riding the Dragon

Focus on what is meaningful in your life: being a good father or mother, helping other people, living in the present moment and enjoying your life. I believe that Taoist meditation can help you to walk the path toward knowing yourself. By gaining a grain of detachment, it becomes easier to stay away from the "merry-go-round" of our society.

Q: When people make unpleasant remarks about me, I notice that I have a tendency to overreact. Can Taoist meditation can help me?

A: Everybody has "buttons." By buttons I mean sensitive spots. When somebody makes a joke about a situation that you cannot handle well, you become suddenly very upset, far beyond the scope of the joke. What I learned over the years is a two-pronged approach:

- a. Become aware of your sensitivities. Pay attention, so you know when somebody accidentally or purposely has touched them.
- b. Do not react when somebody is pushing your buttons. Just watch the buttons being pushed and smile. Do not expect immediate and consistent success. Be diligent, and the success will come.

Taoist meditation will bring you the necessary space between you and your buttons, so you do not automatically react to your friend's jokes. Besides, it is fun to watch somebody who makes a joke that he expects is going to upset you – yet nothing happens. He reacts with surprise, as if something is not going right today.

Actually, you conditioned that person to expect a certain reaction to his jokes. When this is not happening any longer, he does not know what to make of it. Let

him live with his need to poke jokes at others and walk away with a smile. That day you are the winner – not only over him, but over yourself.

Q: Can Taoist meditation help me be less afraid of death?

A: If you practice daily Taoist meditation, you slowly become aware that you are a little part of a big whole. This big entity, called the universe, changes all the time. When you die, you also change into something else. It does not have to be a new human life; it can be a rock, a plant, an animal or a white, fluffy cloud floating in the blue sky. In India people call this process of continuous change reincarnation or the *Wheel of Samshara*.

I believe that the fear of death springs from the feeling of separateness between oneself and nature. However, if you will correctly perceive yourself as an atom in the big scheme of life, your fear will start to vanish. You cannot simply freeze your body and look the way you look right now for the rest of your life. Instead, you may understand that you are not that important for the future of mankind and accept that eventually you will change into something else and this is just fine.



Q: I have some financial difficulties. I believe you do not have this kind of problem, but maybe you can help me with some advice. Will you please?

A: I have financial difficulties as well. Do not make the mistake to believe that I live in a problem-free world. The mastery comes in handy when you do have problems and you know how to handle them well, not when everything comes to you on a silver platter.

About money, try to spend it with moderation; in other words, do not try to live above your means. Also, if you are entrenched in the kind of job that brings you a big paycheck, but you hate the job, you should consider shrinking your ambitions and find some type of work that may not be well paid but brings contentment.



Money is needed for survival, but do not overemphasize the importance of money. Instead, try to focus on other things: self-knowledge, patience, friendship and so on that make life meaningful.

Q: I was acting nasty toward my friend. Afterwards I felt awkward about speaking with him again. What should I do?

A: Be honest with yourself. If you feel guilty, call your friend and acknowledge that you made a mistake and you are sorry. This will help you put all this behind you and help keep your friendship intact.

Q: Do you believe in miracles?

A: Yes, I do. However, I look at miracles from a different perspective than most people do. For me, a miracle happens when someone, against all doubts and difficulties, accomplishes a difficult project over a long period of time. That person, who has the strength to cultivate what he feels is worthwhile and bring to life a beautiful painting, a melodious song, a graceful carving, a meaningful book, performs a miracle.

I read about people who, being touched by a master, all of a sudden become enlightened and all their problems and worries vanish by a magic touch. Well, these are stories, that only happen in books; they do not happen in real life.

To find solutions to problems, it takes more than a magic touch; it takes perseverance, hard work and ability. To overcome difficulties you need to realize who you really are beyond your body and mind.

To live life graciously, detachment is not enough -- you also need to be prepared to handle life's challenges. Accordingly, you develop your skill so when problems arrive you know inside yourself that you can handle them successfully.

Taoist meditation can help you develop the self-confidence that you can face life's problems well and you will not become engulfed in a whirlpool of unforeseen events.



119

Riding the Dragon

Q: I recently suffered a car accident. Another car, without stopping at a stop sign, smashed into my car in the middle of an intersection. I was very close to death and this happened without any apparent reason. I could not stop thinking: why did it happen to me?

A: It is difficult to accept for anybody, but this is the reality: we only have partial control over our life and there is nothing we can do about it. Something unexpected can happen that turns our projects upside down. For example, I went to pass a computer test that I needed to get a networking certification. According to the rules you have roughly 75 seconds to answer a question and if you take longer than that you can fail the test.

I prepared myself well for the test, but this was not enough. At the testing center they were having problems with their computer systems, and the PC I was working at was getting slower and slower until the software completely crashed and I had to stop the test and retake it another time.

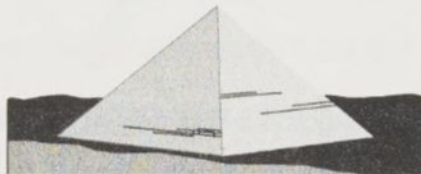


Try to accept the limits of your actions since this can only make your existence easier.

120

Q: When I meditate my mind is quiet. I just sit peacefully with my back straight and enjoy the meditation. Do I still need to go through the six steps at the beginning of my meditation?

A: No, this is no longer necessary. The six steps were designed for people who have a difficult time quieting their mind. If you can do this spontaneously and without any effort, then you do not need to go through the first five steps (they are preparatory anyhow). Just sit still with an empty mind and enjoy your meditation.



In my experience I found out that not all "sittings" are the same. Sometimes if the mind is quiet by itself, I skip the preparatory steps and go straight into meditation.

However, there are times, especially when I have to face difficult problems in my daily life, when the mind is not quiet and then I need to practice all the six steps to have a good meditation.

Q: There are certain things that I do not like about myself and I tried repeatedly to change them without any success. Can you offer some advice that could

The first step toward changing your attitude is to acknowledge your mistakes. You need a clear understanding of what your problems are and then you can continue with some plan for improvement. In other words, you need to be honest with yourself. If you refuse any criticism and you choose to hear only what you like to hear, there is not too much room left for spiritual growth.



Q: When you were talking about detachment, you said: "You are in the midst of the events, but you look at them from the outside, like a witness." What do you mean by looking at life from the outside?

A: First, you need to realize who you really are – pure bliss and compassion. There is no recipe that I know of to find your essence – it just happens when you are ready. You can then observe your own thoughts and actions, but you know that you are not them. You witness them in the same way as you watch a movie, but you know that you are not in the movie, you are only the audience. Since detachment transcends understanding, words do not have power to express it so you have to experience it yourself.



Q: Frequently, when I start to play the Tai Chi form, my mind wanders hither and thither. Should I stop playing, try to become more quiet and then resume playing the form?

A: You may stop for a while, slow down and then carry on with the form. However, I suggest that you should just continue the form and ignore the lack of concentration. After practicing for a few minutes, your mind will become more quiet automatically. Gradually your stance will become lower and your form will become smoother, and one day you will reach a stage when you will forget about your body and mind altogether and you will become one with the form.

Do not try to play a perfect form after a few months of studying Tai Chi Chuan; instead just keep practicing and in due time your form will improve.

Q: Lately, I have a difficult time falling asleep. Do you know any technique that could help?

A: When you lie down in bed, just before going to sleep, try to put your mind in the lower Tan Tien. Focusing on the lower Tan Tien will help you to quiet your mind and therefore to fall asleep easier. Also, you will enjoy a more restful sleep.

In addition, you may try to take a cold shower just before going to bed. It will calm you down and refresh you for the night. If a cold shower is too much for you, at least wash your feet with cold water. This will also help you to sleep better.

Q: I watched several Tai Chi Chuan video tapes and I also visited several masters and I noticed sizable differences in the form from master to master. How do I know which form is correct and which master should I learn with?

A: There are several Tai Chi Chuan styles and everybody is different. So there will always be differences from master to master, and there is no such thing as one form being more correct than the other.

However, there are some criteria that could tell you which form is authentic and which one is a counterfeit. What I have in mind are the Tai Chi Chuan principles, such as tucking in, head suspended, knee on top of toes, twisting the upper body only with the hips staying in place and so on. As long as these principles are followed the form is correct. For a better understanding of the Tai Chi Chuan principles, I suggest you read "Tai Chi Ch'uan Principles and Practice," recommended in the bibliography or some other translation of the Tai Chi Chuan principles as they were originally developed in China.

Q: When you speak about the body and mind, it sounds as if the body and mind are two different entities in juxtaposition to each other. The body and mind, to me, are just two abstract concepts; in reality, there is only one holistic person. Would you agree with me?

A: You are correct. "The body and mind" are just one continuum of energy; while the body is a more gross form of energy, the mind is a more subtle one. The reason I use the body and mind is because these terms are so engraved in our vocabulary that it makes it easier to refer to them.

A better word for mind is thinking process. There are many processes that are going on within us. There are physiological processes like digestion, breathing,

and excretion. Also, there are psychological processes which result in thoughts; hence, I call them thinking processes.

The goal of meditation is the control of the thinking processes. The capacity to stop thinking and just be in the present moment is the result of meditation. Actually, we are born with this capacity, but we lose it in contact with our society. So meditation helps us relearn a long-forgotten gift we had been born with.

Q: I have been practicing meditation for many long years but enlightenment seems as out of reach today as it was the day I first started to meditate. Do you know of any method that could shorten the way to enlightenment?

A: You cannot demand enlightenment. It will come when you are ready, like an apple that falls from an apple tree when it is ripe. The desire to find enlightenment only slows down your meditation process. With patience, the fruits of meditation will soon be within your reach.



Q: Are you an enlightened teacher?

A: We are all enlightened. We are born with this gift and it is innate in all of us. By enlightenment I understand a state of grace, living in harmony with nature and with the other people around us.

If the lake is calm, its surface will clearly reflect our true face. When the mind is quiet you can easily realize your true, blissful nature.

Q: In which faith were you raised and did it influence your life?

A: I do not like to stick a label on myself and I do not believe that one religion is better than another. As such, I do not call myself a Christian, Jew, Buddhist, Yogi or Taoist. Rather than focusing on the label, I focus on the quality of life. I try to be honest with myself and with others and enjoy the time I was granted on this planet.

Q: I am so afraid of life that it paralyzes me. How do you handle fear?

A: There is nothing wrong about being afraid. Fear is part of every living creature, be it human being or animal. It is fear that forces us into action when a danger arises. Therefore, you should not try to suppress your fear; on the contrary, acknowledge your fear and learn to accept it.

What is important is to learn how to control your fear, so rather than your fear being in charge your self-control is in charge. Shift your attention to the lower Tan Tien, breathe deeply with the diaphragm and force yourself to smile. For more details review Meditation Steps, Part 2. Breathing Deeply on page 40. Then decide on the most appropriate course of action and quickly proceed. Taoist meditation, if practiced daily, can help you master your fear.



The Essence

The person who practices Taoist meditation gets closer to Tao. He or she becomes a "real person." Meditation gives you a sense of quietness and contentment. You become more focused. Because you have fewer rough edges, you get through the day in a more pleasant way and avoid confrontations that often make day-to-day life unpleasant.

Everybody wants to be loved. But how do you get other people to love you? The best way to start is by loving oneself. Love begets love and hate begets hate. If you love yourself, other people will love you as well because they will feel attracted by your positive attitude.

Everybody loves those movies wherein the hero, confronted by difficult circumstances, single-handedly saves the day. His confidence and compassion awaken self-confidence and compassion in us. After the movie you feel better, stronger and more willing to understand other people.

When you realize your essence, beyond time and space, a warm love blossoms in your heart. You feel no boundaries between you and nature. Love encompasses everything, including yourself. Meditation helps to find your essence and get in touch with your real Self.

Riding the Dragon

Quite frequently we try to accomplish too many things too fast. Meditation helps us get a different perspective on life, become more detached and be able to slow down, smile and relax. It is written in the "Tao Te Ching,"

"Weaken your ambitions,
Strengthen your essence."

When you meditate, you let go of your ambitions and when you sit still, your essence is strengthened. Trying too hard to achieve too many goals only causes exhaustion, but through the practice of meditation one can see clearly what path to take -- one gets insight. The wisdom of Tao slowly fills our spirit, and we no longer feel like a rudderless boat on a stormy sea. We begin to master our life.

We feel our being is light, like a bubble floating in the blue sky: empty, but at the same time containing everything. We realize that the bliss is present all the time in us, but the restless mind hides it just as clouds sometimes hide the blue sky from us.



APPENDIX

Bibliography

- Baginski, B. S. & S. Shamron. Reiki: Universal Life Force Energy. CA: Life Rhythm, 1988.
- Brahmananda, S. Blue Sky Meditation. New York: Ananda Ashram, 1988.
- Chang, S. T. The Complete System of Self-healing Internal Exercises. San Francisco, CA: Tao Publishing, 1991.
- Chu, C. K. T'ai Chi Ch'uan Principles and Practice. New York: Sunflower Press, 1986.
- Chu, C. K. The Book of Nei Kung. New York: Sunflower Press, 1986.
- Dao, D.M. Daily Meditations. San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1992.
- Das, S. The Snow Lion's Turquoise Mane: Wisdom Tales from Tibet. New York: Harper, San Francisco, 1992.
- Hanh, T. N. Looking Deeply. [Cassette Recording]. Berkeley, CA: Parallax Press, 1987.
- Hanh, T. N. The Heart of Understanding. [Cassette Recording]. Berkley, CA: Parallax Press, 1987.
- Hanh, T. N. Peace Is Every Step. New York: Bantam Books, 1992.
- Hesse, H. Siddhartha. New York: Bantam Books, 1981.
- Hesse, H. The Glass Bead Game (Magister Ludi). New York: Henry Holt and Company, Inc. 1990.
- Hoff, B. The Tao of Pooh. New York: Penguin Books Ltd., 1983.

129

Riding the Dragon

- Hoff, B. The Te of Piglet. New York: Penguin Books Ltd., 1992.
- Hua, E. K. Kung Fu Meditations & Chinese Proverbial Wisdom. Ventura, CA: Thor Publishing Company, 1981.
- Hwa, J. T. The Tao of Meditation: Way to Enlightenment. Piscataway, NJ: Tai Chi Foundation, 1983.
- Iyengar, B. K. S. Light on Yoga. New York: Schocken Books, 1979.
- Kundera, M. L'insoutenable Legerete de L'Etre. France: Gallimard 1989.
- Kushi, M. Macrobiotic Home Remedies. Tokyo and New York: Japan Publications, 1985.
- Maugham, W. S. The Razor's Edge. London: Penguin Books, 1988.
- Milarepa, J. The Hundred Thousand Songs of Milarepa. New York: Shambala Dragon Editions, 1989.
- Norris, Chuck. The Secret Power Within: Zen Solutions to Real Life Problems. New York: Little, Brown and Company, 1996.
- Ohashi, W. Do-it-Yourself Shiatsu. New York: Penguin Group, 1976.
- Ramana, M. Be as You Are: The Teachings of Ramana Maharishi. New York: Routledge & Kegan Paul Inc., 1985.
- Sogyal, R. The Tibetan Book of Living and Dying. San Francisco: Harper, San Francisco, 1992.
- Spock, B. & M. B. Rothenberg. Dr. Spock's Baby and Child Care. New York: Pocket Books, a div. of Simon and Schuster, 1985.
- Tze, L. Tao Te Ching. New York: Harper Perennial, 1988.
- Tzu, S. The Art of War. New York: Shambala Dragon Editions, 1988.
- Unknown. Bhagavat-Gita. Great Britain: Penguin Group, 1967.
- Unknown. The Upanishads. Petaluma, CA: Nilgri Press, 1987.
- Wong, E. Cultivating Stillness: A Taoist Manual for Transforming Body and Mind. Boston, Massachusetts: Shambala Publications Inc., 1992.

130

Glossary

Pronunciation key

[ah] as in father

[ay] as in pay

[ea] as in pea

[oo] as in foot

[oy] as in toy

[o] as in toe

Acupuncture point: Points in the skin along vital "lines of force" (meridians) that control the flow of energy in the body. Acupuncture points can be stimulated not only by needles but also by heat, ultrasound and massage (acupressure). According to the Chinese theory, yin and yang, the two opposite forces in the body (as well as in the universe), can be kept in balance by acupuncture and other methods, so the chi can flow freely and bring both physical and mental well-being.

Asana [ah • sah • nah]: Yoga exercise. In general, asanas are positions that are held without moving.

Ashram [ah • shrahm]: A community where people practice yoga.

Brahman [brah • man]: A high priest in India in the Hindu community.

Brahmananda Sarasvati, Sri: Sri Brahmananda Sarasvati Udasina is the founder of the Yoga Society of New York and Ananda Ashram. He is the author of "Fundamentals of Yoga." He is a very generous, respected and beloved teacher.

131

Riding the Dragon

Brush Knee: Tai Chi Chuan move.

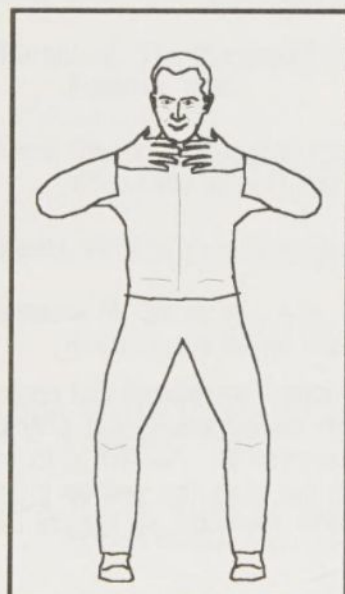
Chen Wei Ming: Tai Chi Chuan master who lived in China at the turn of the century. He is the author of "Questions and Answers by Chen Wei Ming."

Chi [chea]: Vital body energy.

Ching [cheang]: Raw form of energy, also associated with sexual energy.

Chu, C. K.: Master Chu is currently teaching Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung, Push Hands and Taoist meditation at the Tai Chi Chuan Center of New York. He is the author of "Tai Chi Ch'uan Principles and Practice" and "The Book of Nei Kung."

Embrace Horse: Nei Kung exercise.



Front



Lateral

Figure 41 - Embrace Horse

Form: Also known as the Tai Chi form or the Tai Chi Chuan form. A sequence of attack and defensive movements that is usually practiced in slow motion. There are two forms of practice: the Long Form which is the original form practiced in China for hundreds of years and the Short Form which is an abbreviated form for Western consumption. The Long Form takes about 30 to 40 minutes to complete while the Short Form takes

132

Glossary

about 10 to 15 minutes. Because the Tai Chi Chuan form is considered an art, when practicing the form we say "playing the form," like playing a musical instrument.

Ging [jeang]: The strength of a punch or a kick. When the body is rooted to the ground, and the movements are well coordinated and flow easily, and the mind is focused, the body can "deliver a lot of ging" (the punch or kick is very powerful).

Guru [goo • roo]: A Hindu spiritual teacher or head of a religious group. Also, an influential or revered teacher.

Hun [hoy]: The most refined form of energy that pervades all the universe. The literal translation from Chinese for hun is "void."

Jade Pillow Area: A protuberance located where the nape of neck meets the skull. The Jade Pillow Area works like a gate that controls the flow of energy on the dorsal side of the body.

Kick with the Heel: Tai Chi Chuan move.

Kung Fu [koong foo]: Chinese art of fighting; fighting skill.

Long Form: The original Tai Chi Chuan form practiced in China for hundreds of years. It takes 30 to 40 minutes to complete.

Lotus [lo • tus]: The basic Lotus pose (see also Figure 3 and Figure 5) as it is described in "Light on Yoga,"

1. Sit on the floor with the legs straight.
2. Bend the right leg at the knee, hold the right foot with the hands and place it at the root of the left thigh, so that the right heel is near the navel.
3. Now bend the left leg and holding the left foot with the hands place it over the right at the root, the heel being near the navel. The soles of the feet should be turned up."

Mantra [mahn • trah]: A Hindu or Buddhist mystical formula of invocation or incantation that is repeated during prayer or meditation.

Meridian: Channel of energy that runs through the body. Different body organs are associated with specific meridians. For example, the kidney meridian, the liver meridian, the heart meridian, etc.

Nei Kung [knee koong]: Internal system of exercises practiced in order to become more energetic (to generate ching).

Parasympathetic nervous system: The portion of the autonomic nervous system that generally maintains muscle tone, induces secretion and dilates blood vessels.

133

Play Pi Pa [pea pah]: Nei Kung exercise.



Front



Lateral

Figure 42 - Play Pi Pa

Pranayama [prah • nah • yah • mah]: A yoga breathing technique that sometimes involves counting the length of the breath; for example, in the "square pranayama." Pranayama is different from Taoist breathing exercises. While in pranayama the emphasis is on breathing out, in Taoist breathing exercises the emphasis is on breathing in. This leads to quite different results. While pranayama will help you relax, Taoist breathing exercises will fill you up with energy, chi.

Push Hands: A unique sparring exercise in which the two partners develop the skill of deflecting punches using a minimum amount of physical strength. Push Hands often involves using your opponent's power to gain advantage in fighting. There are two forms of Push Hands: One-Hand Push Hands and Two-Hands Push Hands. As the name indicates, in One-Hand Push Hands you use only one hand both for defense and attack and in Two-Hands Push Hands you use both hands for defense and attack. When you train, you alternate the hands and the foot-work. While One-Hand Push Hands makes it easier to learn how to yield and how to "listen to your opponent's gong" (to feel your opponent's strong and weak points and to get away when you are attacked), Two-Hands Push Hands gets closer to real combat. One-Hand Push Hands is a prerequisite for Two-Hands Push Hands. Both forms should be mastered to be able to apply Tai Chi Chuan for self-defense (Push Hands is the application of Tai Chi Chuan for fighting).

Reiki [ray • kea]: Japanese technique used for relaxation and also for energizing the body.

Shen [sun]: Energy associated with spirit. When the body is functioning well and has a lot of chi, the shen is strong and alert. When a person is full of shen, it radiates through the eyes.

Short Form: An abbreviated Tai Chi Chuan form for Western consumption. It takes about ten to fifteen minutes to complete.

Sifu [sea • foo]: Master in Chinese. It also means cook or chef.

Small Orbit: Circuit that surrounds the body longitudinally and through which the chi can circulate. On the ventral side, it goes through the third eye, the solar plexus, the navel, the lower Tan Tien and the perineum. On the dorsal side, it goes through the backbone, the Jade Pillow Area, and the top of the head. The Small Orbit closes where the upper teeth meet the roof of the mouth. By placing the tongue at the connection of the anterior and posterior meridian (see Figure 6), the Small Orbit is closed and the chi can flow freely in the body.

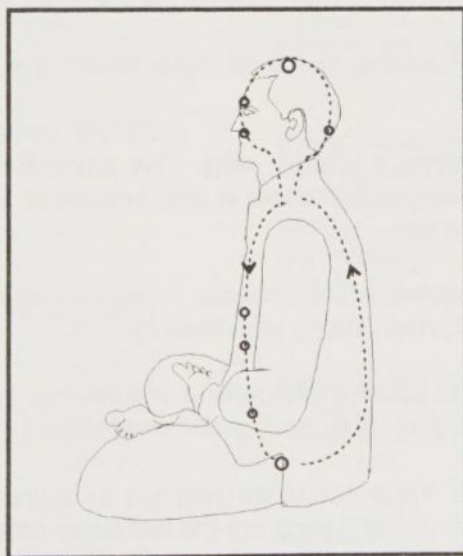


Figure 43 - The Small Orbit

One of the goals of meditation is the cultivation of chi, so the body gets stronger and the mind gets calmer.

Ta Lu [dah loo]: Exercise similar to Push Hands that involves the use of the shoulders, elbows and wide footwork. Also, called "four corners."

Tai Chi Chuan [tie chea choo• wahn]: Also known as Tai Chi. It is an internal Kung Fu system practiced not only for self-defense but also for maintaining a youthful body and mind.

Tan Tien [tahn tea • en]: Nervous plexus. There are three Tan Tien in the body:

1. The lower Tan Tien is located about two inches below navel and one inch inside.
2. The middle Tan Tien is located in the solar plexus area (a conglomerate of nerve cells located in the center of the torso, under the heart and behind the stomach).
3. The upper Tan Tien is located on the forehead, between the eyebrows. Also known as the third eye.

Tao [dah • o]: The universal force harmonizing nature.

Taoism [dah • o • ism]: A Chinese mystical philosophy traditionally founded by Lao Tzu in the 6th century B.C. that teaches conformity to the Tao by unassertive action and simplicity.

Viparita Karani Mudra [vea • pah • rea • tah kah • rah • nea moo • drah]: An inverse asana with the lower part of the body above the upper part.

Walking Push Hands: Exercise similar to Push Hands that involves back-and-forth movements.

Wheel of Samshara [sahm • shah • rah]: The process of death and rebirth as explained by Indian mythology. Samshara is also associated with illusion or something that fades quickly.

Yang [yahng]: The masculine active principle in nature that in Chinese cosmology is exhibited in light and heat. Also, strong and decisive.

Yin [yeen]: The feminine passive principle in nature that in Chinese cosmology is exhibited in darkness and cold. Also, soft, gentle and hesitant.

Yin and Yang Symbol: Yang combines with yin to produce all things and living creatures that come to be. Yin and yang are the two basic components of the universe. They complement and follow each other. Yin springs from yang and yang springs from yin.

Yoga [yo • gah]: A Hindu system of meditation and self-control designed to produce well-being and spiritual insight. The sacred symbol of yoga is the word Aum which means God. It is represented by the Sanskrit sign ॐ.

Index

A

Abdomen circular massage, 50–51
Acupuncture, 19
Acupuncture point, 36, 45, 131
Advanced Breathing Techniques, 71–74
After meditation massage techniques, 45–64
Ankle, left ankle massage, 58
Ankle, right ankle massage, 58
Application of Taoist Meditation in Martial Arts, 87–90
Asana, 60, 61, 78, 131, 136
Ashram, 25, 131
Author, 139

B

Balancing. See Energy balancing technique
Before Meditation Warm-up Techniques, 35–38
Benefits of Taoist Meditation, 21–24
Body, massage, 50–54
Brahman, 72, 129, 131
Brahmananda Sarasvati, Sri, 131
Breathing. See Advanced breathing techniques
Breathing deeply, second step, 40
Brush Knee, 109, 132

C

Chen Wei Ming, 9, 83, 92, 132
Chi, 20, 21, 22, 29, 73, 78, 80, 94, 108, 113, 131, 132, 134, 135
Ching, 80, 132, 133
Chu, C. K., 9, 132
Clockwise, massage, 50
Counterclockwise, massage, 50
Counting, fifth step, 42

D

Deep breathing exercises, first level, 71
Detachment, second stage, 66

E

Embrace Horse, 78, 108, 132
Emptying the mind. See Letting go

Energizing the eyes, 46
Energy Balancing Technique, 62
Essence, 127–28
Eyes, massage, 45–46
Eyes, position, 33

F

Face massage, 45
Face, expression, 33
Feeling the Tan Tien, third step, 41
Fighting skill. See Kung Fu
Foreword, 7–8
Form, 15, 98, 106, 108, 109, 123, 124

G

Ging, 90, 133, 134
Glossary, 131–36
Guru, 24, 106, 133

H

Hands, position, 31–33
Head, massage, 45–49
Head, position, 29
Health, massage applications, 64
Hip, massage, 56
Hun, 80, 133

I

Integration of Taoist meditation into daily life, 75–84
Introduction, 15–16

J

Jade Pillow Area, 47, 48, 49, 133, 135

K

Kick WithThe Heel, 109, 133
Knees, inner side massage, 57
Knees, outer side massage, 57
Knees, under the, massage, 57
Kung Fu, 77, 133, 136

L

Legs, inner side massage, 55
Legs, outer side massage, 55
Legs, position, 30–31
Letting go, sixth step, 43
Long Form, 15, 108, 109, 132, 133
Lotus, 30, 31, 32, 38, 92, 108, 133
Lower abdomen massage, 51–52
Lower back massage, 54

M

Mantra, 42, 72, 133
Massage. See After meditation massage techniques
Meditation Stages, 65–70
Meditation Steps, 39–44
Meridian, 20, 31, 36, 131, 133, 135

N

Nei Kung, 20, 77, 78, 79, 80, 81, 82, 94, 99, 100, 103, 104, 106, 108, 113, 132, 133, 134, 139
Nose, massage, 46–47
Note to the reader, 10
Nutrition, 85–86

P

Parasympathetic nervous system, 26, 133
Personal experiences with Taoist meditation, 25–26
Play Pi Pa, 78, 108, 134
Pranayama, 40, 134
Preface, 9
Prerequisites for successful meditation, 29–34
Push Hands, 78, 88, 89, 90, 98, 99, 103, 104, 106, 108, 113, 132, 134, 136, 139

Q

Questions and answers, 91–126
Quietness, third stage, 67

R

Rapid breathing exercises, second level, 71
Reiki, 19, 76, 135
Relaxation, 63
Rounding out, fourth step, 42

S

Scalp, massage, 48–49
Shen, 22, 80, 135
Short Form, 109, 132, 135

Sifu, 81, 135
Sitting straight, first step, 40
Small Orbit, 49, 73, 74, 135
Solar plexus massage, 52
Stillness, first stage, 65
Stimulating the eyes, 45
Stomach massage, 53
Stretching technique, 59

T

Ta Lu, 99, 136
Table of contents, 11
Tai Chi, 123, 132. See Tai Chi Chuan
Tai Chi Chuan, 9, 15, 77, 78, 79, 80, 81, 82, 87, 88, 90, 94, 97, 98, 99, 100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 105, 106, 108, 109, 110, 111, 112, 113, 114, 123, 124, 132, 133, 134, 136, 139
Tan Tien, 22, 29, 39, 41, 51, 71, 72, 73, 79, 91, 102, 105, 112, 123, 126, 135, 136
Tao, 101, 127, 128, 136
Taoism, 9, 19, 20, 79, 99, 136
Taoist, 7, 8, 9, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 31, 66, 70, 73, 79, 80, 81, 82, 88, 90, 91, 92, 95, 98, 99, 100, 101, 102, 103, 104, 106, 107, 108, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115, 116, 117, 119, 126, 127, 132, 134, 139
Teeth, position, 33
Temples and Ears, massage, 49
Tongue, position, 33

V

Viparita Karani Mudra, 60, 61, 62, 64, 136

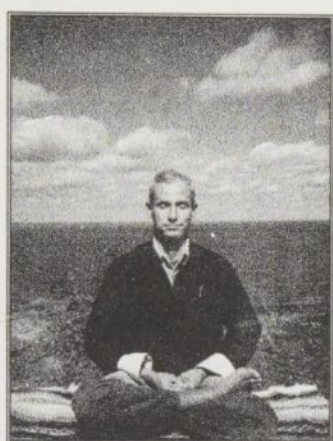
W

Walking Push Hands, 99, 136
Warm-up. See Before meditation warm-up techniques
Wheel of Samshara, 117, 136
Wisdom, fourth stage, 68

Y

Yang, 19, 87, 136
Yin, 19, 87, 136
Yin and Yang Symbol, 87, 136
Yoga, 25, 40, 60, 61, 72, 78, 91, 97, 131, 134, 136, 139
Yoga technique, 60–61

About the Author



Liviu Argeseanu was born in Romania in 1953. He graduated from the University of Bucharest, Romania with a Masters Degree in Science and a major in Nuclear Physics. He came to the United States in 1983. He is currently working in the computer field.

He has been practicing yoga for 20 years, both in the United States and in Romania. However, for the last

10 years he has dedicated himself to the study and teaching of Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung, Push Hands and Taoist meditation.

He has organized and directed the Taoist Meditation Club at York College (Jamaica, Queens).

Since 1994, when he founded the Tai Chi Chuan School of Forest Hills (Queens, New York), he has been teaching Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung, Push Hands and Taoist meditation.

Yin and Yang

*Darkness follows light
and light follows darkness.
Hate follows love
and love follows hate.
Death follows life
and life follows death.*

*From emptiness,
all things come into being.
In meditation,
all things withdraw into emptiness.*

*The best poem is the unwritten one.
The best story is the untold one.
The best teaching is given without words.
The best discipline is self-discipline.*

*Do not lay judgment on somebody else
and you will not be judged yourself.
Do not split right from wrong
and the doors of Heaven will open to you.*

The Warm Rain

It happened by the shores of the Nile and not too far from the magical island of Elephanta. It was a unique place. Camels would carry tourists on an invisible path in the desert to the monuments of the Valley of the Kings.

Bedouins, like memories from another time, slowly led the way by foot holding the reins of the animals. Fellucs, with wide sails rounded by the morning breeze, crossed the Nile like white pelicans landing in the Danube Delta.

I was brought into this quest by a feeling of incompleteness, that something was missing in my life, that something within reach was passing me by without being able to grasp it, like a thirsty man that can see the water well, but by some magic spell cannot drink it. Everything that I did missed that grain of salt that makes life palatable. Nothing could satisfy me. The dryness in my soul pushed me away from home onto this trip that was supposed to end in the caves of the Himalayas.

For now, I removed my sandals and let the hot sands of the Sahara dunes slowly bake my feet. In front of me was a jewel of the Muslim architecture, the monument of Aga Khan. I stepped onto the cool slabs of granite, into the open courtyard that sheltered his relics. On top of the tomb there was a graceful silver vase. A thoughtful hand had put a freshly cut red rose into the vase. There was something in the air that forced me to listen. The time to stop running had come.

I sat on the floor with my legs crossed and my eyes wide open. The red rose was mysteriously drawing my attention. I was staring at the rose and after a while

tears started to flow down my cheeks. Then I closed my eyes, but I could still see the red rose shining in front of me.

After some time, the rose vanished. I could not feel my body any longer. Like a bubble, my soul started to rise slowly into the sky. I did not want to come back. I have had enough with this life. I could see my body getting smaller, and then I forgot my body altogether. I was rising higher and higher. I thought this was the end of my earthly existence.

Suddenly, a warm summer rain started. I stopped rising. Something subtly changed. I felt all my restlessness being washed away into the ground. Then my soul slowly descended back into the body. The limbs felt stiff, as if the owner had left them derelict for quite a while. I had to relearn how to walk and how to talk like a newborn baby, only something fulfilled me inside -- now I could accept myself and look forward to living. After a long time I could "drink" again.

I knew what to do. It was time to go home. Finally, I was at peace with myself. A light smile blossomed on my face and I felt a wide tide of contentment bathing and renewing my whole being.



Order Form

Buyer:

Name: Phone: (.....).....

Address:.....

City: State: Zip:.....

Yes, please send mecopies of Riding the Dragon: a Taoist Meditation Guide at \$25.00 each, plus \$2.00 per book for postage and handling.

Allow 30 days for delivery.

My check or money order, payable to **Apollo Press**, in the amount of \$ is enclosed.



ASK ABOUT OUR QUANTITY DISCOUNTS

Call: (718) 544-6994

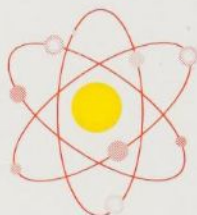
Email address: 102570.3525 @ CompuServe.com.

When we let go of our daily worries and we just sit still, time is perceived differently. Like honey flowing smoothly from a pot, time becomes liquid, and accordingly it loses its grip on us.

2. Breathing deeply

1. Sitting straight

3. Feeling the Tan Tien



6. Letting go

4. Rounding out

5. Counting

The Taoist Meditation Guide introduces a unique method of meditation that facilitates letting go and sitting quietly without thinking. This method also works on conserving and replenishing the energy of the body, "chi."

The Taoist Meditation Guide offers sensible, proven answers to questions that lay people as well as meditation practitioners want to know. One chapter is devoted to Chinese massage techniques that are great at keeping the body and mind in harmony.

This condensed book takes a practical look at how we can integrate Taoist Meditation into daily life. It also gives some insight into what we can expect if we diligently practice meditation over a long period of time.

The Taoist Meditation Guide is not only about meditation, but also touches several related topics like: Tai Chi Chuan, Nei Kung, Yoga, Reiki, application of Taoist Meditation in Martial Arts, warm-up techniques, and nutrition. In order to entice the reader toward the practice of meditation, the book begins by describing some of the benefits of meditation as well as the amazing experiences that the author went through while in meditation.



\$19.95

W7-AWW-155